

SS1 LITERATURE-IN-ENGLISH LESSON NOTES

FIRST TERM

WEEK 1: INTRODUCTION TO LITERATURE

Definition of Literature

Literature, in its broadest sense, refers to the **entire body of written works** of a specific culture, language, or time period. It is a form of art that uses language as its medium.

However, a more focused definition distinguishes "literature" (with a capital 'L') from any random text (like a shopping list or a simple news report). In this sense, Literature is defined as:

Imaginative or creative writing that possesses **artistic merit, aesthetic value, and universal interest**. It explores the human condition, ideas, emotions, and experiences through language that is often crafted, stylized, and intended to be more than just informative.

Key Characteristics:

- **Imaginative:** It is a product of the human imagination (fiction, poetry, drama).
- **Artistic:** It uses language in a skillful and beautiful way (e.g., figures of speech, rhythm, specific narrative structures).
- **Universal:** The themes and ideas (like love, death, conflict, justice) resonate with people across different cultures and time periods.
- **Interpretive:** It is open to interpretation; different readers can find different meanings in the same text.

Literature can be categorized into **oral** (passed down by word of mouth, like folktales, myths, and legends) and **written** (recorded in text).

Functions of Literature

Literature is not just for entertainment; it serves several crucial functions in society and for the individual.

1. To Entertain (The "Sweetening" Function):

- This is the most common function. Literature provides pleasure, escapism, and aesthetic delight.
- It engages our imagination and emotions through compelling stories, beautiful language, and dramatic tension. This is the "sweetness" (Latin: *dulce*) that draws us to a story.

2. To Educate and Inform (The "Instructive" Function):

- Literature teaches us about the world, different cultures, historical periods, and human psychology.
- It provides moral lessons, philosophical insights, and vicarious experiences (allowing us to "live" through a situation without actually being there). This is the "utility" or "instruction" (Latin: *utile*).

3. To Mirror Society (The "Reflective" Function):

- Literature often acts as a mirror, reflecting the values, beliefs, problems, vices, and virtues of the society in which it was created.
- It documents the human experience of a particular era, capturing the *zeitgeist* (the spirit of the times).

4. To Critique Society (The "Corrective" Function):

- Literature does not just reflect society; it often criticizes it.
- Authors use stories, poems, and plays to expose injustice, corruption, and societal ills (e.g., in satire), often aiming to provoke thought and inspire change.

5. Cultural Preservation:

- Literature serves as an archive of a people's culture, language, myths, and history. It carries the identity of a culture from one generation to the next.

6. Emotional and Psychological Development:

- By exploring the inner lives of characters, literature helps us understand our own emotions and the emotions of others, thereby developing empathy.

Importance of Studying Literature

Studying literature is a fundamental part of a rounded education for several reasons:

- **Development of Critical Thinking:** Literature is complex and ambiguous. Analyzing a text requires you to interpret data (the words on the page), identify patterns, form a hypothesis (an interpretation), and support it with evidence.
- **Improved Language and Communication Skills:** Reading widely expands your vocabulary, exposes you to complex sentence structures, and shows you the power of effective expression. This, in turn, improves your own writing and speaking skills.
- **Cultivation of Empathy:** Literature allows you to step into the shoes of others—people from different backgrounds, cultures, and time periods. This "vicarious experience" fosters empathy and a deeper understanding of human nature.
- **Broadened Worldview:** It breaks down the boundaries of your own limited experience, introducing you to new ideas, philosophies, and perspectives you might never have encountered otherwise.
- **Understanding of History and Culture:** Literature provides a personal and human context for historical events. You don't just learn *that* a war happened; you learn what it *felt* like for the people living through it.

Evaluation

1. In your own words, provide a comprehensive definition of Literature.
2. Explain the "reflective" and "corrective" functions of literature using a single example for both.
3. Which of the functions of literature do you consider most important, and why?
4. List three specific skills a student gains from studying Literature-in-English.

Assignment

Write a 200-word essay on the topic: "The Importance of Literature in the Modern Age of Science and Technology."

WEEK 2: LITERARY APPRECIATION

Meaning of Literary Appreciation

Literary appreciation is the process of **analyzing, understanding, and evaluating** a work of literature to discover *how* and *why* it creates its specific effects.

It is more than just "liking" a book. Appreciation involves:

- **Analysis:** Breaking down the text into its individual components (like plot, character, and setting).
- **Interpretation:** Determining what the text *means* and what message the author is trying to convey.
- **Evaluation:** Assessing the text's artistic quality, its effectiveness in achieving its goals, and its overall impact on the reader.

Literary appreciation is the skill of reading *deeply* and *critically*, moving beyond the surface-level story to understand the craft behind it.

Elements of Literary Appreciation

To appreciate a literary work, we analyze its key elements. While these elements are present in all genres, they are most often discussed in relation to **prose** (novels and short stories).

1. Theme:

- **Definition:** The **central idea, message, or underlying meaning** of the text. It is a universal truth or observation about life and the human condition that the author explores.
- **Note:** A theme is *not* a single word (e.g., "Love"). It is a statement *about* that word (e.g., "Love can be a destructive force" or "True love requires sacrifice").
- A text can have a **major theme** (the most important one) and several **minor themes**.

2. Plot:

- **Definition:** The **sequence of related events** that make up the story. It is the "what happens" in the narrative.
- A typical plot structure (often called **Freytag's Pyramid**) includes:
 - **Exposition:** The beginning, where characters, setting, and the initial conflict are introduced.
 - **Rising Action:** A series of complications and obstacles that build tension and develop the conflict.
 - **Climax:** The highest point of tension, the "turning point" of the story, where the conflict comes to a head.
 - **Falling Action:** The events that occur after the climax, where the tension decreases and the consequences of the climax unfold.
 - **Resolution (or Dénouement):** The end of the story, where the conflict is resolved and a new sense of normality (or a "new normal") is established.

3. Setting:

- **Definition:** The **time (temporal) and place (physical)** in which the story occurs.
- **Physical Setting:** The geographical location (e.g., a city, a jungle, a room).
- **Temporal Setting:** The time period (e.g., the 19th century, during a war, over the course of one day).
- **Social/Cultural Setting:** The customs, values, and social norms of the society in the story.
- Setting is crucial as it can influence the plot, affect the characters' behavior, and help create the mood.

4. Style:

- **Definition:** The **author's unique way of using language**. It is *how* the author writes, not *what* they write about.
- Style includes:
 - **Diction:** The author's choice of words (e.g., formal, informal, simple, complex, concrete, abstract).
 - **Syntax:** The arrangement of words into sentences (e.g., long, flowing sentences or short, choppy ones).

- **Use of Literary Devices:** How often the author uses metaphors, similes, imagery, etc.

5. **Tone:**

- **Definition:** The **author's or narrator's attitude** toward the subject matter or the audience.
- The tone is conveyed through diction, plot events, and character descriptions.
- **Examples of Tone:** Serious, humorous, cynical, sarcastic, optimistic, critical, nostalgic, formal.

6. **Mood (or Atmosphere):**

- **Definition:** The **general feeling or emotional atmosphere** that the text creates in the **reader**.
- **Note (Tone vs. Mood):** Tone is the *author's* feeling; Mood is the *reader's* feeling.
- Setting is a primary tool for establishing mood (e.g., "a dark and stormy night" creates a gloomy, tense mood).
- **Examples of Mood:** Suspenseful, joyful, mysterious, terrifying, peaceful, melancholic.

Evaluation

1. Differentiate clearly between 'Tone' and 'Mood'.
2. What is the difference between a 'plot' and a 'theme'?
3. Draw Freytag's Pyramid and label its five parts.
4. Explain the three components of 'Setting'.

Assignment

Read a short story provided by your teacher (or any simple folktale you know). In one page, identify and describe its: a) Main Theme b) Plot (summarize the 5 key stages) c) Setting d) The overall Mood of the story.

WEEK 3: LITERARY DEVICES I (FIGURES OF SPEECH)

Meaning of Figures of Speech

Figures of Speech (also called literary or rhetorical devices) are words or expressions used in a **non-literal** or imaginative way to create a special effect, emphasize a point, or make language more vivid, poetic, and memorable.

They are tools that writers use to "paint pictures with words" and convey meaning beyond the simple, dictionary definitions (denotation) of the words.

Analysis of Specific Figures of Speech

1. Simile:

- **Definition:** A figure of speech that makes a direct comparison between two (dissimilar) things, using the words "**like**" or "**as**".
- **Function:** To make a description more vivid and relatable by linking an unknown or abstract concept to a known or concrete one.
- **Examples:**
 - "He is as **brave as** a lion." (Compares the man's bravery to a lion's)
 - "The memory faded **like** a dream." (Compares the memory's disappearance to a dream's)
 - "My love is **like** a red, red rose."

2. Metaphor:

- **Definition:** A figure of speech that makes an **implied or direct comparison** between two (dissimilar) things, stating that one thing *is* the other. It **does not** use "like" or "as."
- **Function:** A stronger comparison than a simile. It forces the reader to see the similarities between the two items more deeply.
- **Examples:**
 - "He **is** a lion in the fight." (He isn't literally a lion; he is brave and fierce.)
 - "All the world's **a stage**." (Shakespeare)

- "She has a **heart of stone**."

3. Irony:

- **Definition:** A figure of speech or literary device where there is a **contrast or discrepancy between expectation and reality**.
- There are three main types:
 - **Verbal Irony (Sarcasm):** A speaker says the opposite of what they actually mean. (e.g., Stepping into a hurricane and saying, "Lovely weather we're having.")
 - **Situational Irony:** The outcome of a situation is the opposite of what was expected. (e.g., A fire station burns down; a traffic policeman gets his license suspended for unpaid parking tickets.)
 - **Dramatic Irony:** The audience or reader knows crucial information that a character in the story does not. This creates suspense or humor. (e.g., In a horror movie, the audience knows the killer is in the closet, but the character does not.)

4. Personification:

- **Definition:** A figure of speech in which **inanimate objects, animals, or abstract ideas** are given **human qualities, emotions, or actions**.
- **Function:** To make abstract concepts more tangible or to create a more vivid and relatable image.
- **Examples:**
 - "The **wind whispered** through the trees." (Wind cannot whisper.)
 - "**Justice is blind**." (Justice is an abstract idea; it cannot be blind.)
 - "The **sun smiled** down on us."

5. Oxymoron:

- **Definition:** A figure of speech that combines **two contradictory or opposite words** side-by-side to create a new, complex meaning.
- **Function:** To create a dramatic effect, highlight a paradox, or express mixed emotions.
- **Examples:**
 - "**Jumbo shrimp**"

- "Living dead"
- "Deafening silence"
- "A bittersweet memory."

Evaluation

Identify the figure of speech in each of the following sentences:

1. "The car engine coughed, sputtered, and finally died."
2. "Her new dress is a perfect mess."
3. "Tolu is a snake; you cannot trust him."
4. "The student felt as light as a feather after the exam."
5. The audience knew that Romeo was only sleeping, but Juliet thought he was dead. (Name the specific type of irony).

Assignment

Write a short poem (at least 8 lines) describing a market scene. In your poem, you must correctly use and label at least **one** example of Simile, Metaphor, and Personification.

WEEK 4: LITERARY DEVICES II (ADDITIONAL FIGURES OF SPEECH)

Analysis of Additional Figures of Speech

This week, we continue our exploration of the tools writers use to add depth and color to their work.

1. Euphemism:

- **Definition:** The substitution of a **mild, indirect, or vague expression** for one thought to be offensive, harsh, or blunt.
- **Function:** To soften a harsh reality, to be polite, or (sometimes) to be deceptive.
- **Examples:**
 - "He **passed away**." (Instead of "He died.")
 - "She is **between jobs**." (Instead of "She is unemployed.")
 - "The company is **downsizing**." (Instead of "Firing people.")

2. Alliteration:

- **Definition:** The repetition of the **same initial consonant sound** in a series of words or phrases.
- **Function:** To create rhythm, to be memorable (like in tongue-twisters), and to draw attention to the phrase.
- **Examples:**
 - "She sells seashells by the seashore."
 - "The wicked witch of the West."
 - "Pride and Prejudice."

3. Hyperbole:

- **Definition:** A figure of speech that uses **extreme exaggeration** for the sake of emphasis or humor. It is not meant to be taken literally.
- **Function:** To emphasize a point, express strong emotion, or create a humorous effect.
- **Examples:**
 - "I'm so hungry **I could eat a horse**."
 - "I've told you **a million times**."

- "This bag **weighs a ton.**"

4. Allusion:

- **Definition:** An **indirect reference** to a well-known person, place, event, literary work, or piece of art (e.g., from the Bible, mythology, history, or Shakespeare).
- **Function:** To add a deeper layer of meaning by connecting the text to a larger cultural or historical context. It relies on the reader's "shared knowledge."
- **Examples:**
 - "He was a real **Samaritan** about it." (Biblical allusion to the "Good Samaritan.")
 - "She had a **Mona Lisa smile.**" (Allusion to Leonardo da Vinci's painting.)
 - "He has an **Achilles' heel.**" (Mythological allusion to a point of weakness.)

5. Assonance:

- **Definition:** The repetition of **vowel sounds** within words in a sentence or line (e.g., a, e, i, o, u).
- **Function:** To create internal rhyme, musicality, and a specific mood.
- **Note (Assonance vs. Alliteration):** Alliteration is about *initial consonant* sounds; Assonance is about *internal vowel* sounds.
- **Examples:**
 - "The **rain** in Spain falls **mainly** on the **plain.**" (Repetition of the /ei/ sound)
 - "Try to light the **fire.**" (Repetition of the /i/ sound)

6. Paradox:

- **Definition:** A statement that appears to be **self-contradictory or absurd** but, upon closer inspection, reveals a deeper truth or meaning.
- **Function:** To make the reader pause and think critically about an idea.
- **Note (Paradox vs. Oxymoron):** An Oxymoron is two *words* (e.g., "living dead"). A Paradox is a full *statement* or concept (e.g., "The child is father to the man").
- **Examples:**
 - "You must be **cruel to be kind.**"
 - "War is **peace.**" (From George Orwell's *1984*)
 - "This is the **beginning of the end.**"

7. Repetition:

- **Definition:** The intentional act of **repeating a word, phrase, or sentence** for literary effect.
- **Function:** To create emphasis, to build rhythm or suspense, or to highlight a central theme.
- **Examples:**
 - **"Rage, rage** against the dying of the light." (Dylan Thomas)
 - In Martin Luther King Jr.'s speech: **"I have a dream..."** (This specific type of repetition at the beginning of clauses is called *anaphora*).

Evaluation

Identify the dominant figure of speech in each sentence:

1. "His new car is a 'pre-owned' vehicle."
2. "The bright light blinded my eyes."
3. "He's a modern-day Romeo with the ladies."
4. "I had to wait an eternity for the bus."
5. "Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers."
6. "This sentence is a lie." (Explain why this is a paradox).

Assignment

Write a 1-page (250-word) story about a rainy day. In your story, you must correctly use and label at least **one** example of: a) Hyperbole b) Assonance c) Alliteration d) Euphemism

WEEK 6: GENRES/BRANCHES OF LITERATURE

Overview of the Three Genres

All works of literature are categorized into three main "genres" or branches. A genre is a category characterized by similarities in form, style, or subject matter.

The three major genres are **Prose, Poetry, and Drama**.

Prose

- **Definition:** Prose is written or spoken language in its **ordinary form, without metrical structure**. It is the language we use in everyday speech, in textbooks, novels, and newspaper articles.
- It is characterized by its use of **sentences and paragraphs**.

Structural Features of Prose:

- **Sentence:** The basic unit of thought.
- **Paragraph:** A group of related sentences that develop a single idea.
- **Chapter:** A major division of a prose work, especially a novel.
- **Narrative Voice/Point of View:** The perspective from which the story is told (e.g., First Person "I"; Third Person "He/She/They").

Sub-genres of Prose:

- **Fiction:** Imaginative writing (not real).
 - **Novel:** A long, complex fictional narrative (e.g., *Things Fall Apart*).
 - **Novella:** Shorter than a novel, longer than a short story.
 - **Short Story:** A brief narrative, focused on a single incident or character.
- **Non-Fiction:** Factual writing (real).
 - **Biography:** A story of a person's life written by someone else.
 - **Autobiography:** A story of a person's life written by that person.

- **Essay:** A short piece on a specific subject.

Poetry

- **Definition:** Poetry is a genre of literature that uses **aesthetic and rhythmic qualities of language** (such as meter and rhyme) to evoke meaning and emotion. It is language used in its most compressed, intense, and artistic form.
- It is characterized by its use of **lines and stanzas**.

Structural Features of Poetry:

- **Line:** The basic structural unit of a poem (a single "sentence" of the poem).
- **Stanza:** A group of lines forming a unit in a poem, similar to a paragraph in prose.
- **Rhyme:** The repetition of similar sounds, usually at the end of lines.
- **Rhyme Scheme:** The pattern of rhymes (e.g., A-B-A-B).
- **Rhythm/Meter:** The "beat" of the poem, created by the pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables.
- **Enjambment:** When a line of poetry continues onto the next line without punctuation, creating a "run-on" line.

Sub-genres of Poetry:

- **Lyric Poetry:** Expresses personal emotions or feelings (e.g., Sonnet, Ode).
- **Narrative Poetry:** Tells a story (e.g., Epic, Ballad).
- **Dramatic Poetry:** Poetry written in the voice of a character (e.g., Dramatic Monologue).

Drama

- **Definition:** Drama (a play) is a work of literature **designed to be performed on a stage** by actors. It is a story told primarily through **dialogue and action**.

Structural Features of Drama:

- **Dialogue:** The conversation between two or more characters.
- **Monologue/Soliloquy:** A long speech by a single character (A soliloquy is when they are alone, revealing inner thoughts).
- **Stage Directions:** Instructions (usually in italics or parentheses) from the playwright indicating movement, setting, or tone.
- **Act:** A major division of a play (like a chapter in a novel).
- **Scene:** A subdivision of an Act, usually representing a single location or time.
- **Characters:** The *dramatis personae*, or persons of the drama.

Sub-genres of Drama:

- **Tragedy:** A serious play with a downbeat ending, often involving the downfall of the main character (e.g., *Antony and Cleopatra*).
- **Comedy:** A light-hearted play intended to amuse, usually with a happy ending.
- **Tragicomedy:** A play that blends elements of both tragedy and comedy.
- **Melodrama:** A highly sensationalized play with exaggerated emotions.

Evaluation

1. Create a table that clearly lists the three genres and their primary structural units (e.g., Prose uses...).
2. What is the main difference between prose and poetry in terms of language?
3. What feature makes drama unique from both prose and poetry?
4. Define 'Soliloquy' and 'Stage Directions'.

Assignment

Find one example of each genre (a short poem, a one-page short story, and a one-page script/play scene—you can find these online or in books). Read them and write one paragraph for each, explaining *how* you knew which genre it belonged to based on its structural features.



WEEK 8: SHAKESPEAREAN TEXT: *ANTONY AND CLEOPATRA* I

Background of William Shakespeare

- **Who:** William Shakespeare (1564–1616) is widely regarded as the **greatest writer in the English language** and the world's pre-eminent dramatist.
- **Where:** He was born in Stratford-upon-Avon, England, but worked in London as an actor, playwright, and part-owner of the "Lord Chamberlain's Men" (later "The King's Men") acting company.
- **When:** He wrote during the **Elizabethan Era** (named for Queen Elizabeth I) and the **Jacobean Era** (named for King James I).
- **What:** He wrote approximately 38 plays, 154 sonnets, and other poems. His plays are typically categorized as **Tragedies** (*Hamlet*, *Macbeth*), **Comedies** (*A Midsummer Night's Dream*), and **Histories** (*Henry V*).

Background and Setting of *Antony and Cleopatra*

- **Genre:** This play is a **Tragedy** and also a **Roman Play** (or "History Play," as it is based on historical events).
- **Source:** Shakespeare's main source was **Plutarch's *Lives of the Noble Grecians and Romans***, which provided the historical account of Mark Antony's life.
- **Historical Context:** The play is set after the assassination of Julius Caesar (44 BC). The Roman Republic is controlled by a **Triumvirate** (a council of three rulers):
 1. **Mark Antony**
 2. **Octavius Caesar** (Julius Caesar's grand-nephew and heir)
 3. **Marcus Lepidus** (a weaker, older general)
- **Setting (Thematic Conflict):** The play's action is split between two contrasting worlds:
 - **Rome (The West):** Represents duty, order, reason, law, masculinity, and military discipline. It is the world of Octavius.
 - **Egypt (The East):** Represents passion, pleasure, chaos, emotion, femininity, and indulgence. It is the world of Cleopatra.

- The central conflict of the play is Antony's struggle, as he is torn between his Roman duty and his Egyptian passion.

Plot Summary (Acts I–II)

Act I

- **Scene 1 (Egypt):** We are introduced to **Mark Antony** in Alexandria, Egypt. He is completely infatuated with **Cleopatra**, the Queen of Egypt. Roman soldiers complain that their great general has abandoned his duty and "dotage" (become foolishly old and in love). Messengers arrive from Rome, but Antony refuses to see them, declaring, "Let Rome in Tiber melt... Here is my space."
- **Scene 2 (Egypt):** The Roman messengers finally deliver their news: Antony's wife, **Fulvia**, has waged war against Octavius Caesar and has died. Simultaneously, **Sextus Pompey** (a pirate/rebel) is gaining power at sea, threatening Rome.
- **The Conflict:** This bad news forces Antony's hand. He feels a "Roman thought" and realizes he must break free from Cleopatra's spell and return to Rome to handle his responsibilities.
- **Scene 4 (Rome):** We meet **Octavius Caesar** and **Lepidus**. Octavius criticizes Antony's decadent lifestyle in Egypt, contrasting it with his past as a great, disciplined soldier. This scene establishes the cold, calculating, and dutiful nature of Octavius.
- **Scene 5 (Egypt):** Cleopatra languishes, missing Antony, and sends messengers to him daily. We see her dramatic, vain, and manipulative, yet genuinely passionate, nature.

Act II

- **Scene 2 (Rome):** The Triumvirate (Antony, Octavius, Lepidus) meets. Octavius and Antony argue fiercely. To heal the rift and form a political bond, Lepidus and Agrippa (Octavius's advisor) suggest a plan: **Antony should marry Octavius's sister, Octavia.**
- **The Marriage:** Antony agrees to the political marriage. Octavia is described as the opposite of Cleopatra: she is virtuous, quiet, and devoted to Roman duty.

- **Scene 3 (Rome):** A Soothsayer (fortune-teller) warns Antony that his "guardian angel" (his spirit) will always be weaker than Octavius's. He tells Antony to leave Rome and stay away from Octavius. Antony recognizes this truth and decides to return to Egypt.
- **Scene 5 (Egypt):** A messenger arrives in Egypt and tells Cleopatra the news that Antony has married Octavia. Cleopatra flies into a violent rage, beating the messenger and refusing to believe it. This shows the depth of her passion and her royal temper.
- **Scene 7 (On Pompey's Ship):** The Triumvirate has made peace with Sextus Pompey. They celebrate with a drunken feast on his ship. Pompey's men suggest they kill the three rulers and take over the world, but Pompey refuses, saying it would be dishonorable (though he wishes it had been done without his knowing). This scene shows the Romans (especially Antony) engaging in "Egyptian" levels of indulgence, and it highlights Lepidus as weak and foolish.

Evaluation

1. Who was William Shakespeare, and during which two eras did he write?
2. What is the "Triumvirate" in the context of the play?
3. Contrast the settings of "Rome" and "Egypt" as they are presented in the play.
4. Why does Antony agree to marry Octavia in Act II?

Assignment

In a 200-word paragraph, analyze the character of Mark Antony as he is presented in Acts I and II. Is he a great leader, a foolish old man, or something in between? Use evidence from the plot summary.

WEEK 9: SHAKESPEAREAN TEXT: *ANTONY AND CLEOPATRA* II

Plot Summary (Acts III–V)

Act III

- **The Breach:** Antony, Octavia, and Lepidus go their separate ways. Antony, despite being married to Octavia, immediately returns to Egypt and Cleopatra.
- **Antony in Alexandria:** In a public ceremony, Antony divides the Eastern Roman Empire among Cleopatra and her children (including Caesarion, her son by Julius Caesar). This act is a direct insult to Octavius and a political betrayal of Rome.
- **Rome's Reaction:** Octavius learns of this and uses it as propaganda. He has already imprisoned Lepidus (on false charges) and now declares war on Antony—or rather, he declares war on Cleopatra, cleverly painting Antony as her bewitched puppet. Octavia returns to Rome, heartbroken.
- **The Battle of Actium (Act III, Scene 10):** This is the climax of the play. It is a naval battle. Against the advice of his best soldier, **Enobarbus**, Antony decides to fight Octavius at sea (where Octavius is strongest) simply because Cleopatra wants him to.
- **The Defeat:** During the battle, Cleopatra's 60 ships suddenly flee. Antony, in his "dotage," "whose will is 'Antony'," turns his own ship and **follows her**, abandoning his men and the fight.
- **The Aftermath:** Antony is filled with shame. Enobarbus, seeing that his master has lost all honor and judgment, decides to desert Antony and join Octavius.

Act IV

- **Antony's Decline:** Antony tries to challenge Octavius to single combat, but Octavius mocks him, refusing to fight a "tired old man."
- **Enobarbus's Death:** Enobarbus, now with Octavius, is overcome with guilt when Antony sends his treasure after him. Enobarbus realizes the "world" and "his master" have been "cast away" and dies of a broken heart.

- **The Final Battle:** Antony wins a small victory on land, which briefly restores his spirits. However, in the final naval battle, his entire fleet (the Egyptian fleet) surrenders to Octavius.
- **Antony's Suicide Attempt:** Believing Cleopatra has betrayed him, Antony is furious. Cleopatra, fearing his rage, locks herself in her monument (tomb) and sends a false message that **she has committed suicide**.
- **Antony's Death:** Hearing this, Antony's rage turns to grief. He asks his servant, Eros, to kill him. Eros kills himself instead. Antony then falls on his own sword, but fails to die instantly. He is brought, bleeding, to Cleopatra's monument and is lifted up to her. He dies in her arms, advising her to trust Octavius's man, Proculeius (which is bad advice).

Act V

- **Cleopatra's Capture:** Octavius Caesar arrives in Egypt. He wants Cleopatra *alive*. He plans to capture her and parade her through the streets of Rome in his "triumph" (victory parade), which for Cleopatra, would be the ultimate humiliation.
- **Cleopatra's Plan:** Cleopatra pretends to negotiate with Octavius, but she is secretly planning her own death. She knows he will betray her.
- **The Suicide:** A "clown" (a country peasant) brings Cleopatra a basket of figs, which secretly contains **asps** (poisonous snakes).
- **Cleopatra's Death:** Cleopatra, dressed in her finest royal robes, applies one asp to her breast and another to her arm. She dies, not in shame, but in a "royal" and "noble" way, imagining she is reuniting with Antony. Her serving women, Iras and Charmian, also die.
- **The End:** Octavius Caesar enters to find her dead. He is frustrated that he was outwitted, but he also respects her noble end. He orders that she and Antony be buried together in a magnificent tomb. The play ends with Octavius as the sole, undisputed ruler of the Roman world, but the "immortal" love of Antony and Cleopatra has stolen the show.

Themes

1. **Love vs. Duty (Passion vs. Reason):** This is the central theme. Antony is torn between his passionate love for Cleopatra (representing Egypt) and his duty to Rome as a soldier and triumvir (representing Octavius).
2. **The Clash of Cultures (East vs. West):** Rome (West) values order, masculinity, duty, and self-control. Egypt (East) values emotion, femininity, pleasure, and excess. The play shows these two value systems in mortal combat.
3. **Honor and Betrayal:** Characters constantly question what "honor" means. Is it Roman duty? Or is it loyalty to a person (Antony to Cleopatra)? Characters betray each other constantly: Antony betrays Octavia; Enobarbus betrays Antony; Octavius betrays Lepidus.
4. **Power and Politics:** The play is a high-stakes political drama. The "love story" is the catalyst for a massive civil war to decide who will rule the entire Roman world.
5. **Transformation and Decay:** The play charts Antony's transformation from "the triple pillar of the world" into a "strumpet's fool." It also shows the "decay" of the old world of heroes to make way for the new, cold, "efficient" world of Octavius.

Characterization

- **Mark Antony:** The **tragic hero**. He is passionate, charismatic, and a brilliant soldier, but he is also impulsive, self-indulgent, and lacks the self-control of his rival. He is "a man of qualities," but his "dotage" on Cleopatra leads to his downfall.
- **Cleopatra:** The **heroine**. She is "a woman of infinite variety." She is vain, manipulative, dramatic, and cruel (beating the messenger). Yet, she is also fiercely intelligent, politically savvy, powerful, and ultimately, possesses a "nobility" that allows her to die on her own terms rather than be shamed.
- **Octavius Caesar:** The **antagonist** (or, from a Roman perspective, the hero). He is the opposite of Antony: cold, calculating, unemotional, and ruthlessly efficient. He represents the "new Rome." He does not act on passion, only on political advantage. He "wins" the world but fails to understand the passion that drove Antony and Cleopatra.

- **Enobarbus:** Antony's loyal soldier. He acts as the play's **commentator or chorus**. He is cynical and witty, and he sees the truth of the situation (e.g., his famous speech describing Cleopatra on her barge in Act II). His decision to leave Antony, and his subsequent death from guilt, shows the tragic depth of loyalty and betrayal in the play.
- **Octavia:** Antony's Roman wife. She is the **symbol of Roman duty and virtue**. She is a pawn in the political game, and her quiet dignity contrasts sharply with Cleopatra's "serpent-like" passion.

Evaluation

1. What is the "Battle of Actium," and why is it the turning point of the play?
2. Explain the main conflict in the theme of "Love vs. Duty" as it relates to Antony.
3. Compare and contrast the characters of Cleopatra and Octavia.
4. Why does Enobarbus die? What does his death symbolize?

Assignment

Write a 250-word essay answering the question: "Who is the true tragic hero of *Antony and Cleopatra*? Is it Antony, or is it Cleopatra? Justify your choice with evidence from the plot."

WEEK 10: SHAKESPEAREAN TEXT: *ANTONY AND CLEOPATRA* III

Language and Style

Shakespeare's language in *Antony and Cleopatra* is considered some of his most complex, rich, and "poetic."

- **Blank Verse:** Like most of his plays, it is written primarily in **blank verse**. This is **unrhymed iambic pentameter**.
 - **Iambic:** A "foot" of poetry with one unstressed syllable followed by a stressed syllable (da-DUM).
 - **Pentameter:** There are *five* of these "feet" in each line (da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM).
 - *Example:* "Let **Rome** in **Tiber** **melt**, and **the** wide **arch**..."
 - **Effect:** This rhythm closely mimics natural English speech while also giving it a formal, elevated, and powerful sound.
- **Hyperbole (Exaggeration):** The language of the play is *grandiose* and *exaggerated*, reflecting the high stakes and epic passions of the characters. The characters don't just "love"; they "melt" empires.
 - *Example (Enobarbus describing Cleopatra):* "Age cannot wither her, nor custom stale / Her infinite variety." He describes her as a goddess who defies time.
 - *Example (Antony):* "Kingdoms are clay: our "p"easy-rooted" d "p"alate"s "p"refer" / The "p"oor "p"ortion" "p"of" "p"otatoes"..." (just kidding, that's not it!) ...
"Kingdoms are clay: our "p"easy-rooted" d "p"alate"s "p"refer" / The "p"oor "p"ortion" "p"of" "p"otatoes"..." (just kidding, that's not it!).
 - *Example (Antony):* "Kingdoms are clay: our "p"alate"s "p"refer" / The "p"oor "p"ortion" "p"of" "p"otatoes"..." (that's not right).
 - *Example (Antony):* "Kingdoms are clay: our "p"alate"s "p"refer" / The "p"oor "p"ortion"..." (that's not right either).
 - *Example (Antony):* "Let Rome in Tiber melt, and the wide arch / Of the ranged empire fall!"
- **Shift in Style:**

- **Rome:** The language spoken in Rome (by Octavius) is often plainer, more direct, and "prose-like" (even when it's verse). It is logical and businesslike.
- **Egypt:** The language spoken in Egypt (by Antony and Cleopatra) is poetic, hyperbolic, and overflowing with rich imagery. It is the language of passion.

Imagery

Imagery is the use of descriptive language that appeals to the five senses. In this play, Shakespeare uses patterns of imagery to reinforce the themes.

1. World and Cosmos (The "Globe"):

- The characters constantly see themselves in cosmic terms. Antony is the "triple **pillar of the world**." Octavius "holds the **world**" in his hands.
- Cleopatra compares Antony to the **sun** and **moon**.
- **Effect:** This imagery reinforces the idea that their personal love story is not just a private affair; it is an epic, world-changing event that will decide the fate of the "globe" (which was also the name of Shakespeare's theatre!).

2. Water and Sea:

- The sea is central to the play. It is the source of Rome's power (its navy) and Egypt's wealth (the River Nile).
- The **Nile** is used as an image of fertility, mystery, and excess (like Egypt and Cleopatra).
- The **Battle of Actium** (at sea) is the turning point, where Antony's "world" drowns.

3. Animals:

- **Serpent:** Cleopatra is constantly referred to as the "**serpent of old Nile**." This is ambiguous: it suggests she is dangerous, tempting, and sinful (like the serpent in Eden), but also that she is wise, ancient, and regenerative (like a snake shedding its skin). She dies by the "asp's" bite.

- **Horse:** The horse is an image of Roman masculinity and war (Antony's "war-horse"). Antony's decline is shown by his failure to control this image.

Dramatic Techniques

These are the tools Shakespeare uses *as a playwright* (not just a poet) to create effects on stage.

1. **Contrast:** The entire play is built on contrasts.
 - **Rome vs. Egypt** (Setting, Values)
 - **Octavius vs. Antony** (Character: cold vs. hot)
 - **Cleopatra vs. Octavia** (Character: passionate vs. virtuous)
 - **Public vs. Private:** The play rapidly shifts between scenes of "public" life (battle strategies, political arguments) and "private" life (lovers' quarrels, intimate moments). This shows how their private passion has disastrous public consequences.
2. **Foreshadowing:** Hints of what is to come.
 - The **Soothsayer** in Act II telling Antony he will always lose to Octavius directly foreshadows Antony's defeat.
 - Enobarbus's speeches, while witty, often foreshadow the doom that is to come.
3. **Dramatic Irony:** The audience often knows more than the characters.
 - The most famous example: When Antony is dying, he believes Cleopatra is dead. The audience *knows* she is alive, making his suicide doubly tragic.

Relevance to Modern Society

Although set 2,000 years ago, *Antony and Cleopatra* remains relevant because its core themes are timeless.

- **The Conflict of Passion and Responsibility:** Every person experiences the pull between what they *want* to do (passion, love) and what they *should* do (duty, work, responsibility). Antony's struggle is a grand-scale version of this.
- **Political Power and Propaganda:** The play is a masterful depiction of "spin." Octavius wins not just by military might, but by controlling the narrative—painting Antony as a degenerate and himself as the savior of Rome. This is highly relevant in our modern age of media, "fake news," and political branding.
- **The Nature of Love and Relationships:** The play asks difficult questions. Is the relationship between Antony and Cleopatra a "great" love, or is it toxic, selfish, and mutually destructive? Their relationship, with its high drama, passion, and jealousy, reflects modern (and often unhealthy) celebrity culture.
- **Clash of Cultures:** In a globalized world, the "clash" between different value systems (e.g., "East vs. West," traditional vs. modern) is still a major source of conflict, just as it was for Rome and Egypt.

Evaluation

1. What is "blank verse"?
2. Explain the symbolic meaning of the "serpent" imagery as it relates to Cleopatra.
3. Name two "dramatic techniques" Shakespeare uses and provide an example of one from the play.
4. In your opinion, what is the *most* relevant theme of *Antony and Cleopatra* for a modern audience? Justify your answer.

Assignment

Write a 1-page (250-word) newspaper article from the perspective of a Roman journalist, describing the "scandalous" behavior of Mark Antony in Egypt (as described in Act III). Use a "Roman" tone (critical, focused on duty and "spin").

WEEK 11: REVISION

This week is dedicated to a comprehensive review of all topics and texts covered during the first term.

Summary of Key Concepts

- **Week 1 (Introduction):** Literature is the imaginative use of language to explore the human condition. It functions to entertain, educate, mirror society, critique society, and preserve culture.
- **Week 2 (Appreciation):** Appreciation means analyzing the *how* and *why* of a text. The key elements are **Theme** (message), **Plot** (events), **Setting** (time/place), **Style** (author's language), **Tone** (author's attitude), and **Mood** (reader's feeling).
- **Weeks 3 & 4 (Devices):** Writers use Figures of Speech (non-literal language) to create effects.
 - **Comparisons:** Simile (like/as), Metaphor (is).
 - **Contradictions:** Irony (opposite of expected), Oxymoron (contradictory words), Paradox (contradictory statement).
 - **Sound:** Alliteration (initial consonants), Assonance (internal vowels).
 - **Others:** Personification (human qualities), Hyperbole (exaggeration), Euphemism (softening language), Allusion (indirect reference), Repetition (emphasis).
- **Week 6 (Genres):**
 - **Prose:** Ordinary language (paragraphs, chapters).
 - **Poetry:** Rhythmic/stylized language (lines, stanzas, meter).
 - **Drama:** Written for performance (acts, scenes, dialogue).
- **Weeks 8–10 (*Antony and Cleopatra*):**
 - **Plot:** Antony, one of three rulers of Rome, falls in love with Cleopatra, Queen of Egypt. He abandons his Roman duty (and his Roman wife, Octavia) for her. This sparks a civil war with his rival, Octavius Caesar. Antony's passion causes him to lose the crucial Battle of Actium. Believing false reports of Cleopatra's death, he commits suicide. Cleopatra then commits suicide (by asp) to avoid being captured and shamed by Octavius.

- **Characters:** Antony (passionate, flawed hero), Cleopatra (dramatic, powerful heroine), Octavius (cold, political victor), Enobarbus (cynical commentator).
- **Themes:** Love vs. Duty, East vs. West, Power, Honor, Transformation.
- **Style:** Blank verse, cosmic imagery, and dramatic contrasts.

Final Term Assignment (To be submitted as part of exam preparation)

Answer **one** of the following questions in a well-structured essay of 300–400 words.

1. Using any three figures of speech learned this term (e.g., Metaphor, Personification, Irony), explain how they function in a literary text. Why are they more effective than literal language?
2. Compare and contrast the three genres of literature (Prose, Poetry, and Drama) based on their structural features and their unique ways of telling a story.
3. "In *Antony and Cleopatra*, Octavius Caesar wins the world, but Antony and Cleopatra win the audience's imagination." Discuss this statement, explaining why the "losers" of the play are considered its true heroes.

SS1 LITERATURE-IN-ENGLISH LESSON NOTES

SECOND TERM

WEEK 1: INTRODUCTION TO AFRICAN DRAMA

FEATURES OF AFRICAN DRAMA

African drama is a unique and vibrant art form deeply rooted in the traditions and experiences of the continent. It is not simply "drama written by Africans" but a form with specific, recognizable characteristics that differentiate it from Western theatre.

- **Communal and Functional:** Unlike Western "art for art's sake," traditional African drama is highly functional. It serves a specific purpose in the community: to educate, to resolve conflict, to perform religious rites, or to mark historical events. It is a communal experience that involves and reflects the entire society.
- **Integration of Art Forms:** African drama is a "total theatre." It does not separate art forms. It fluidly combines **dialogue with music, song, dance, mime, and spectacle**. A play is an event, a celebration, not just a series of spoken words.
- **Audience Participation:** The "fourth wall" (the invisible barrier between the actors and the audience) rarely exists. The audience is an active participant. They may join in songs (call-and-response), offer comments to the actors, or even become part of the performance space.
- **Use of Masks and Costumes:** Masks are not just decorations. They are powerful symbolic tools used to represent gods, ancestors, spirits, or archetypal characters. They are transformative, allowing the actor to embody a supernatural or symbolic force.
- **Ritualistic and Ceremonial Roots:** Much of African drama originates from religious rituals, festivals (like the *Mmanwu* masquerade of the Igbo), and ceremonies. This gives it a serious, spiritual, and communal depth.
- **Didacticism (Teaches a Lesson):** African drama is almost always didactic. It aims to teach moral lessons, social values, and the community's history. The "story" is a vehicle for a "message."

ORAL TRADITION AND CULTURAL ELEMENTS IN AFRICAN PLAYS

African drama is the direct descendant of African oral tradition. The playwright is the modern-day *griot* or storyteller.

- **The Role of the Storyteller/Narrator:** Many African plays (like Efua Sutherland's *The Marriage of Anansewa*) use a Storyteller or Narrator. This character speaks directly to the audience, guides the plot, and provides commentary, exactly as a traditional storyteller would.
- **Myths, Legends, and Folktales:** The plots are often drawn from the vast library of African oral narratives. Playwrights adapt well-known folktales (like the Ananse (spider) stories) or historical legends to comment on modern issues.
- **Proverbs and Riddles:** The dialogue is rich with proverbs, idioms, and riddles. In African culture, "proverbs are the palm-oil with which words are eaten" (Chinua Achebe). Using them demonstrates wisdom, and they are a form of compressed, poetic communication.
- **Symbolism:** The plays are non-naturalistic. A stool can represent kingship, a pot of water can represent life or purity, and an animal (like the Tortoise) can represent a human quality (cunning).
- **Language:** Many African playwrights code-switch, blending indigenous languages with English, French, or Portuguese. They also forge a new "African" English, infusing it with local syntax, rhythms, and imagery (e.g., Wole Soyinka, J.P. Clark).

EVALUATION

1. List five key features of traditional African drama.
2. What is "total theatre" in the context of African drama?
3. Explain the role of "audience participation."
4. How does African drama use "proverbs"?

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 200-word paragraph explaining the difference between a traditional African play and a typical Western (e.g., European) play you have seen or read about, focusing on (a) the use of music and (b) the role of the audience.



WEEK 2: AFRICAN DRAMA: BOSEDE ADEMILUA-AFOLAYAN'S *ONCE UPON AN ELEPHANT*

BACKGROUND OF THE PLAYWRIGHT

Bosede Ademilua-Afolayan is a Nigerian academic, playwright, and literary critic. She is a professor at the University of Lagos, specializing in drama, theatre, and gender studies. A key area of her academic and creative work is **ecocriticism**, which is the study of the relationship between literature and the physical environment. This focus is the single most important key to understanding *Once Upon an Elephant*. She uses the stage to explore environmental issues and their connection to human society.

BACKGROUND OF THE TEXT

Once Upon an Elephant is a modern Nigerian play that functions as a **fable** or **allegory**.

- **Fable/Allegory:** The play uses animals as its characters. However, these animals are not just animals; they represent human beings and different aspects of society. The animal kingdom, "Animalu," is a metaphor for a human nation (like Nigeria) or the world at large.
- **Ecocritical Drama:** The play is a work of ecocriticism. The central conflict revolves around the environment and the control of natural resources (like water). It uses the animal fable to critique human greed, political corruption, and the mismanagement of the environment that leads to suffering for the common people (or, in this case, "common animals").
- **Folktale Roots:** The title *Once Upon an...* immediately signals that we are in the world of folktales, similar to the "Tortoise" stories. The play borrows the *form* of the folktale (talking animals, a clear moral) to deliver a very modern and serious message.

SETTING

The play is set in "**Animalu**," a fictional animal kingdom suffering from a severe drought. The main locations are the **palace of King Elephant (Elerin)** and the general forest area where the

other animals gather. The setting is symbolic: the dry, parched land represents a kingdom that is spiritually and politically "dry" due to its leader's failures.

PLOT SUMMARY OF ACT ONE

- **Exposition:** The play opens in the kingdom of Animalu, which is in crisis. There is a terrible drought, and the animals are suffering from thirst and hunger. The central water source, the "Odo," has dried up.
- **The Problem:** We learn that the suffering is not just a natural disaster. **King Elephant (Elerin)**, the ruler, has used his immense power and resources to build a private, concrete reservoir. He has diverted the last remaining springs into his personal pool, which he uses for his own pleasure, hoarding the water while his subjects thirst.
- **The King's Character:** King Elephant is portrayed as a **tyrant**. He is arrogant, selfish, greedy, and completely indifferent to the suffering of his people. He sees the kingdom's resources as his personal property.
- **The Gathering of Animals:** The other animals—led by the wise and cunning **Tortoise (Alawin)**, the strong but cautious **Lion (Oba L-O-L)**, and including characters like the **Hyena** (a sycophant), the **Deer**, and the **Rabbit**—gather to discuss their plight. They are angry and desperate.
- **The Conflict:** The central conflict is established: **The People vs. The Corrupt Leader**. The animals must find a way to challenge King Elephant's authority and regain access to the water for the good of the community.
- **The Plan:** The Tortoise, in his traditional role as the "trickster" and "brain," begins to formulate a plan. The animals realize that they cannot defeat the Elephant with "might" (force) but must use "wit" (intelligence). Act One ends with the animals, united by their suffering, agreeing to follow the Tortoise's plan to confront the king.

EVALUATION

1. Who is Bosede Ademilua-Afolayan, and what is her main academic focus?
2. What is an "allegory"? How is *Once Upon an Elephant* an allegory?

3. Describe the character of King Elephant as seen in Act One.
4. What is the central conflict of the play?

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 250-word essay on the topic: "The setting of 'Animalu' is more than just a forest. Discuss the symbolic importance of the drought and the King's private reservoir in Act One."



WEEK 3: AFRICAN DRAMA: *ONCE UPON AN ELEPHANT II*

PLOT SUMMARY (ACT TWO)

Act Two is the **climax** and **resolution** of the play.

- **The Confrontation:** The animals, led by the Tortoise (Alawin), march to the King's palace to present their grievances. King Elephant, in his arrogance, dismisses them. He threatens them and boasts of his power.
- **The Trick:** The Tortoise puts his plan into action. He knows the King's weakness is his ego and greed. The Tortoise tells the King that the kingdom's "inaction" has angered the "gods of the land" and that a "great flood" is coming to punish him and wash away his stolen water.
- **The King's Fear:** The Hyena, or another sycophant, tries to dismiss the Tortoise. But the King, despite his power, is superstitious. The Tortoise presents "evidence" (perhaps a clever manipulation of the weather or a pre-arranged "sign"). The King, who believes he is all-powerful, is terrified of a power *greater* than himself (the gods/nature).
- **The Climax:** The Tortoise's trick works. The King panics. He is made to believe that his only way to appease the gods is to "release" the hoarded water back to the land, to "show mercy."
- **The King's Downfall/Re-education:** In a moment of panic, King Elephant orders his reservoir to be broken. The water flows out, replenishing the land and saving the animals. The King's "power" (the hoarded water) is lost.
- **Resolution:** The animals rejoice. The drought is broken, not by the gods, but by the King's own hand, tricked by the wisdom of the Tortoise. The King is left humbled, his power broken, and his authority gone. The play ends with a clear moral: a ruler who hoards the "commonwealth" for himself will ultimately be defeated by the collective will of the people and the wisdom of the "small."

THEMES

- **ABUSE OF POWER AND POLITICAL CORRUPTION:** This is the central theme. King Elephant is a metaphor for corrupt political leaders who see public office as a means of personal enrichment (hoarding water) rather than public service.
- **ECOCRITICISM AND ENVIRONMENTAL JUSTICE:** The play is a direct critique of environmental mismanagement. The "hoarded water" is a symbol of all natural resources (oil, minerals, forests) that are exploited by a powerful few, leading to environmental degradation (drought) that affects the masses.
- **RESISTANCE AND REVOLUTION (WIT VS. MIGHT):** The play champions intelligence over brute force. The animals cannot defeat the Elephant physically. Their "revolution" is one of cunning and strategy, led by the Tortoise. It shows that the oppressed can and will find ways to overthrow the oppressor.
- **JUSTICE AND EQUITY:** The play argues for a fair and equitable distribution of communal resources. The water belongs to everyone, not just the King.
- **THE ROLE OF THE TRICKSTER:** The Tortoise (Alawin) embodies the classic African folktale trickster. He is a force for change, a "chaotic good" character who breaks down a corrupt system to create a new, more just one.

CHARACTERIZATION

- **KING ELERIN (THE ELEPHANT):**
 - **Role:** The protagonist and antagonist (a "villain-protagonist").
 - **Traits:** Arrogant, tyrannical, greedy, selfish, foolish, and short-sighted.
 - **Symbolism:** He represents corrupt leadership, political "godfathers," and the destructive force of unchecked greed.
- **ALAWIN (THE TORTOISE):**
 - **Role:** The true hero and "brain" of the operation.
 - **Traits:** Wise, intelligent, patient, strategic, and courageous. He understands his enemy's psychology.
 - **Symbolism:** He represents the "common man" (though he is small), wisdom, and the power of intelligence to effect change. He is the classic trickster-hero.
- **OBA L-O-L (THE LION):**
 - **Role:** A secondary power.

- **Traits:** He has strength but lacks the wisdom or courage of the Tortoise. He is cautious, perhaps representing an older, more traditional power structure that is also oppressed by the Elephant.
- **THE HYENA:**
 - **Role:** The sycophant or "praise-sinner."
 - **Traits:** A cowardly flatterer who supports the King to get "scraps from the table."
 - **Symbolism:** He represents the enablers of corrupt regimes—those who support tyranny for personal gain.

EVALUATION

1. How do the animals finally defeat King Elephant in Act Two?
2. Explain the theme of "Ecocriticism" in the play.
3. What does the Tortoise (Alawin) symbolize in the play?
4. Contrast the characters of King Elerin and the Hyena.

ASSIGNMENT

Discuss *Once Upon an Elephant* as a political allegory. Who do King Elephant, the Tortoise, and the other animals represent in a modern society (e.g., Nigeria)? (300 words).

WEEK 4: AFRICAN DRAMA: EFUA SUTHERLAND'S *THE MARRIAGE OF ANANSEWA*

BACKGROUND OF THE PLAYWRIGHT

Efua Sutherland (1924–1996) was a pioneering Ghanaian playwright, director, and cultural activist. She is considered the "mother" of modern Ghanaian theatre. She founded the Ghana Drama Studio in Accra, which became a hub for a new kind of theatre—one that was distinctly African but also modern. Her work was dedicated to blending the forms of traditional Ghanaian oral performance with the structure of modern literary drama.

BACKGROUND OF THE TEXT

The Marriage of Anansewa is Efua Sutherland's most famous play. It is the perfect example of her theatrical vision.

- **Anansegoro:** Sutherland called this new form of theatre "Anansegoro," which literally means "Ananse-play." Ananse, the spider, is the most famous trickster figure in Ghanaian (Akan) folklore.
- **What is Anansegoro?** It takes the *elements* of traditional Ananse storytelling and puts them on a modern stage. These elements include:
 1. **A Storyteller (Narrator):** Who controls the "story-telling" event.
 2. **Ananse (the character):** The clever, greedy, lovable, and often-in-trouble trickster.
 3. **Songs and Dance (*Mboguo*):** Musical interludes that comment on the action, express emotion, or allow the audience to participate.
 4. **A Clear Moral Lesson.**
- **Tradition vs. Modernity:** The play is a commentary on modern Ghana (and Africa), where old traditions (like marriage customs) are colliding with new, modern, capitalist desires (the desire for money).

PLOT SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS OF ACT ONE

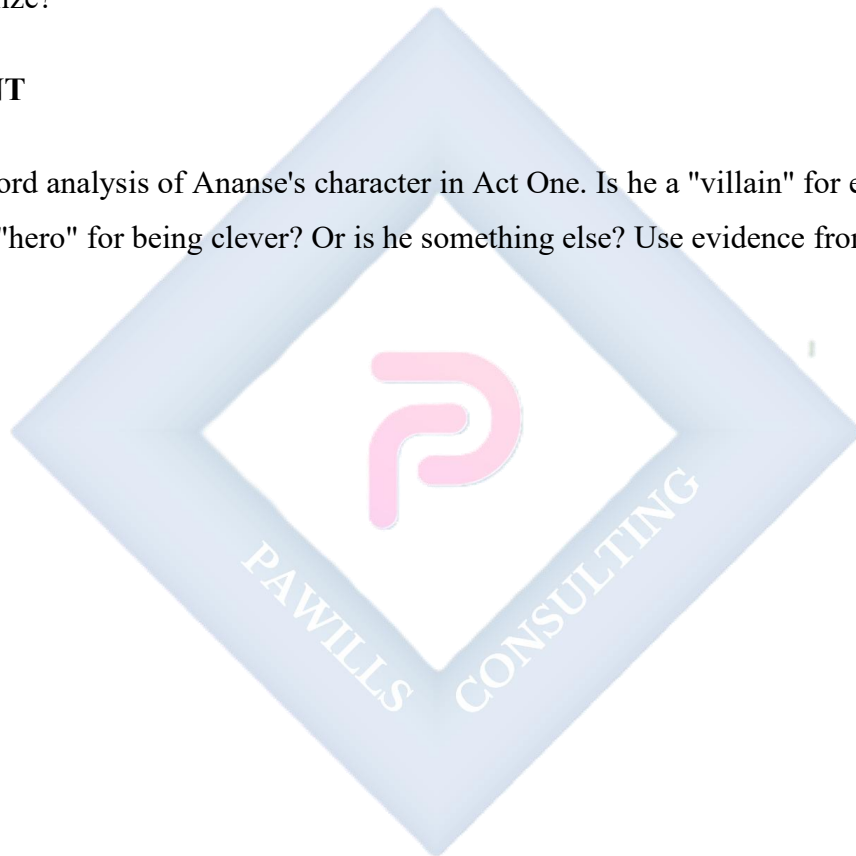
- **Exposition:** The play opens in Ananse's "poor-man's" home. We are introduced to **Ananse**, the father, and his beautiful, educated daughter, **Anansewa**.
- **Ananse's "Big Idea":** Ananse is poor but cunning. He devises a "get-rich-quick" scheme. He will "sell" his daughter, Anansewa, for marriage... to **four different chiefs** at the same time.
- **The Scheme:** He doesn't want to complete the marriages. He wants to keep all four suitors "on the line" indefinitely, so they will all keep sending him "head-drinks" (traditional gifts and money) to win his favour.
- **Tradition and Modernity:** The brilliance of the play is in the *method*. Ananse, the traditional trickster, uses a very **modern** tool to enact his scheme: a **typewriter**. He sits at his typewriter and dictates comically flattering letters to the four chiefs, promising Anansewa to each of them.
- **The Suitors:** The four suitors are:
 1. **Chief-Who-Is-Chief** (The most powerful and wealthy)
 2. **Togbe Delume** (A chief known for his "voodoo")
 3. **Chief Sapa**
 4. **Chief Daga**
- **Anansewa's Role:** Anansewa is not just a victim. She is **complicit** (a partner) in her father's scheme, at least at first. She has been "schooled" by her father to be a "modern" girl who can attract these wealthy men. She poses for photographs in different outfits (a "city" girl, a "traditional" girl) for him to send to the chiefs.
- **The Mboguo:** Throughout the act, the action is interrupted by the **Storyteller** and the "Players" (a chorus). They perform songs and dances (the *Mboguo*) that comment on Ananse's greed, the beauty of Anansewa, and the nature of marriage. This is the "Anansegoro" form, breaking the "fourth wall" and inviting the audience to be part of the storytelling.
- **Act One Climax:** The plan works. Gifts and money begin to pour in from all four chiefs. Ananse is rich! He celebrates, but the Storyteller warns the audience: "What happens when a man spiders a web...?" The act ends with Ananse feeling triumphant, but the audience knows this complicated web must eventually collapse.

EVALUATION

1. Who is Efua Sutherland, and what was her main goal in theatre?
2. Define "Anansegoro" and list its key elements.
3. What is Ananse's "get-rich-quick" scheme in Act One?
4. What modern tool does Ananse use to enact his traditional scheme? What does this symbolize?

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 250-word analysis of Ananse's character in Act One. Is he a "villain" for exploiting his daughter, or a "hero" for being clever? Or is he something else? Use evidence from the text.



WEEK 6: AFRICAN DRAMA: *THE MARRIAGE OF ANANSEWA II*

(This lesson covers the rest of the play, primarily Acts 2-4)

PLOT SUMMARY (CONTINUED)

- **The Crisis:** Ananse's web collapses. All four chiefs, having sent so many gifts, are growing impatient. They all send messengers announcing that they are coming to **claim their bride** on the **same day**.
- **Ananse's New Scheme:** Ananse is trapped. He cannot produce Anansewa for all four. To save himself, he devises an even more outrageous plan: **Anansewa must "die."**
- **The Fake Funeral:** Ananse announces that his beautiful daughter has suddenly and tragically died. He calls all four chiefs, not as suitors, but as **mourners** to her funeral. His new plan is to collect "funeral donations" from them—the last bit of money he can squeeze out of them.
- **The Test:** The chiefs arrive for the funeral, one by one. This is the play's great test. Each chief gives a speech (an "oration") about the "dead" Anansewa. Their speeches reveal their true character. Some are more concerned with the money they've lost than the girl.
- **The Climax (Anansewa's "Resurrection"):** The last chief to arrive is **Chief-Who-Is-Chief**. His speech is different. He is not angry about the money; he is genuinely heartbroken. He speaks of his true love for Anansewa and his sorrow for her loss. He then performs the "final" traditional rite, claiming her as his "wife in death."
- **The Resolution:** Because he is the only one who has shown true love and respect, Ananse "resurrects" his daughter. He claims it is a miracle, that Chief-Who-Is-Chief's love has brought her back to life. The other chiefs, exposed as less noble, have no choice but to accept this. Anansewa, now "alive" again, is given to the one worthy suitor. Ananse has succeeded, not just in getting rich, but in finding the *best* husband for his daughter.

THEMES, STYLE, AND CHARACTERIZATION

THEMES

- **GREED AND CUNNING:** This is a classic Ananse story. It explores the nature of greed (Ananse's scheme) but also celebrates cunning and intelligence.
- **TRADITION VS. MODERNITY:** The play is a critique of how modern, capitalist greed can corrupt beautiful traditions (like marriage customs and even funerals). Ananse turns everything into a "business."
- **APPEARANCE VS. REALITY:** Nothing is what it seems. Anansewa is not dead. The chiefs are not all noble. Ananse's wealth is a sham. The play is about looking past the "appearance" (money, status) to find the "reality" (true love, integrity).
- **THE ROLE OF WOMEN:** Anansewa is not just a passive pawn. She is educated, clever, and an active participant in the scheme. Her "death" is an act of "testing" the suitors, giving her the power to *choose* the right man.

STYLE

- **ANANSEGORO:** The play's unique form, blending storytelling, drama, music, and dance.
- **THE STORYTELLER:** He is crucial. He controls the "event," talks to the audience, and leads the *Mboguo*.
- **MBOGUO (CHORIC INTERLUDES):** These are the songs and dances performed by the "Players." They act as commentary, summarize the action, and express the emotions of the characters, all while involving the audience.
- **PROVERBS AND LANGUAGE:** The language is rich, poetic, and full of Akan proverbs and humor.

CHARACTERIZATION

- **ANANSE:** The central character. He is the **trickster**—greedy, manipulative, and selfish. But he is also charming, imaginative, and a loving father. The audience is forced to admire his cleverness even as they condemn his greed.
- **ANANSEWA:** The "object" of the scheme who becomes its "subject." She is modern and educated ("typing"), but also traditional and obedient. Her "resurrection" is her moment of power, where she secures her own happy ending.

- **CHIEF-WHO-IS-CHIEF:** The only "real" suitor. He represents integrity, true love, and respect for tradition. He "wins" Anansewa because he is the only one who values *her* more than the *money*.
- **THE STORYTELLER AND PLAYERS:** They are the voice of the community, guiding the audience's response and ensuring the play's moral is understood.

CULTURAL VALUES AND MORAL LESSONS

- The play celebrates traditional Ghanaian culture (storytelling, music) while simultaneously **critiquing its abuse**.
- **Moral 1:** Greed leads to complications and ruin.
- **Moral 2:** True love and integrity are more valuable than money and status.
- **Moral 3:** The play teaches that "tradition" is not static; it must be adapted to modern life, but its core values (like respect, love, and community) must be protected from corruption.

EVALUATION

1. Why does Ananse decide to "kill" Anansewa (fake her death)?
2. What is the function of the *Mboguo* in the play?
3. How is Chief-Who-Is-Chief different from the other suitors?
4. Explain the theme of "Tradition vs. Modernity" using Ananse as an example.

ASSIGNMENT

"Ananse is a villain who exploits his daughter and his culture for money." Do you agree or disagree? Write a 300-word argument, using evidence from the play.

WEEK 8: NON-AFRICAN DRAMA: J. B. PRIESTLEY'S *AN INSPECTOR CALLS* I

BACKGROUND OF THE PLAYWRIGHT

John Boynton (J. B.) Priestley (1894–1984) was a prominent English novelist, playwright, and broadcaster. He was a very political writer. Priestley was a **socialist**, and he was deeply concerned with social inequality and injustice. He believed that the wealthy, capitalist class was selfish and that society could only be improved if people took **collective responsibility** for one another. This political belief is the entire foundation of *An Inspector Calls*.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The "when" of this play is its most important feature.

- **WHEN IT IS *SET*: 1912.** This is Edwardian England, just before World War I. It was a time of extreme social rigidity and class division. The wealthy factory-owning class (like the Birlings) lived in luxury, while the working class (like Eva Smith) had no rights or safety net. It was a time of false optimism—Mr. Birling famously says the *Titanic* is "unsinkable," which the audience knows is tragically wrong.
- **WHEN IT WAS *WRITTEN*: 1945.** This is at the very end of World War II. Priestley (and his audience) had just lived through two world wars, a Great Depression, and the near-destruction of Europe. They knew that the "selfish" attitudes of 1912 had led directly to this disaster. In 1945, Britain was looking to build a new, fairer society (the "Welfare State").
- **THE PLAY'S PURPOSE:** Priestley sets the play in the *past* (1912) to warn the *present* (1945). He is telling his audience: "Look at the arrogance and selfishness of these people (the Birlings). This is what caused our problems. We must *never* go back to this. We must learn to be responsible for each other."

SETTING

The play is set entirely in **the dining room of the Birling family's house** in the industrial town of Brumley. This single, claustrophobic setting is symbolic. The room is "substantial" and

"prosperous," but "not cosy." The Birlings are trapped in this "pressure cooker" with the Inspector, and their "bubble" of wealth is about to be burst.

PLOT SUMMARY (ACTS I–II)

ACT ONE

- **The Celebration:** The play opens with the Birling family—**Arthur Birling** (the father), **Sybil Birling** (the mother), **Sheila** (the daughter), and **Eric** (the son)—celebrating. Sheila is engaged to **Gerald Croft**, the son of a rival business owner.
- **Mr. Birling's Philosophy:** Mr. Birling gives a self-satisfied speech about capitalism, saying "a man has to mind his own business and look after himself and his own—and—"
- **The Inspector Arrives:** Just as he says this, the doorbell rings. **Inspector Goole** arrives. He is a mysterious, imposing man who says he is investigating the suicide of a young working-class girl named **Eva Smith**.
- **The "Chain of Events":** The Inspector explains that a "chain of events" led to her death. He proceeds to interview the family, one by one.
- **MR. BIRLING'S INVOLVEMENT:** The Inspector reveals that Mr. Birling knew Eva Smith. She worked at his factory. He **fired her** two years ago for being a "ringleader" in a strike asking for a small pay raise (from 22.5 to 25 shillings a week). Mr. Birling feels no remorse.
- **SHEILA'S INVOLVEMENT:** The Inspector reveals that Eva, now jobless, found work at a dress shop (Milward's). Sheila **got her fired** from that job too. Sheila, in a fit of jealousy and bad temper, complained about the girl's "impertinence" (Eva had smiled when Sheila was trying on a dress). Unlike her father, Sheila is horrified and immediately feels remorse.

ACT TWO

- **GERALD'S INVOLVEMENT:** Sheila suspects that Gerald also knew the girl. The Inspector reveals that he did. Last summer, Gerald "rescued" a girl named **Daisy Renton** (who the Inspector confirms was Eva Smith) from an abusive local politician. Gerald kept her as his **mistress** in a set of rooms. He gave her money and attention when he was with

her, but **abandoned her** when it suited him. Gerald is ashamed, but tries to justify his actions.

- **MRS. BIRLING'S INVOLVEMENT:** The Inspector turns to Mrs. Birling. We learn she is the head of a women's charity. A few weeks ago, a pregnant, desperate young woman—calling herself "Mrs. Birling"—came to the charity for help. Mrs. Birling, offended by the girl's "impertinence" and her use of the Birling name, **used her influence to deny her any help**. She callously told the girl that "the father was responsible" and he should be the one to help.
- **The Climax of Act Two:** The Inspector pushes Mrs. Birling, "And you told her to go and look for the father?" "Yes... I blame him entirely." Sheila, realizing the horrible truth, begs her mother to stop... but Mrs. Birling walks right into the trap. She says the father "should be made an example of." The Inspector says, "Then wait," as **Eric Birling** walks back into the room. The act ends on this cliffhanger.

EVALUATION

1. Explain the importance of the play being *set* in 1912 but *written* in 1945.
2. What is J.B. Priestley's main political belief, and how does it appear in the play?
3. Summarize Mr. Birling's and Sheila's involvement with Eva Smith.
4. How did Mrs. Birling contribute to the death of Eva Smith?

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 250-word analysis of the character of Sheila in Acts I and II. How does she change after the Inspector's arrival, and how does her reaction contrast with her parents'?

WEEK 9: NON-AFRICAN DRAMA: *AN INSPECTOR CALLS II*

PLOT SUMMARY (ACT THREE)

- **ERIC'S INVOLVEMENT:** Act Three begins with **Eric Birling's** confession. He is the "father" that Mrs. Birling had just condemned. He reveals that he met Eva (he knew her as "Daisy") at a bar, got drunk, and forced his way into her home. They had a brief, sordid affair. When she told him she was pregnant, he panicked and **stole money** from his father's office to support her. Eva refused to take the stolen money, proving she had more morals than he did.
- **The Inspector's Final Speech:** With all secrets revealed, the Inspector delivers his final, powerful speech. He is no longer just an investigator; he is a moral prophet. He says, "There are millions and millions and millions of Eva Smiths and John Smiths... We don't live alone. We are members of one body. We are responsible for each other... I tell you that the time will soon come when, if men will not learn that lesson, then they will be taught it in fire and blood and anguish."
- **The Inspector Leaves:** He walks out, leaving the family shattered.
- **The "Hoax" Investigation:** After he leaves, the Birlings (led by Mr. Birling and Gerald) start to question the Inspector's legitimacy. Gerald makes a phone call and confirms **there is no "Inspector Goole"** on the local police force. Mr. Birling calls the hospital—**no girl has died** from suicide today.
- **The Family Divides:** Mr. Birling, Mrs. Birling, and Gerald are overjoyed. They believe the whole thing was a clever hoax. They mock Eric and Sheila and are eager to "go on" just as they were before, covering up the scandal.
- **The Young vs. The Old:** **Sheila** and **Eric** are horrified by their parents' reaction. They argue that it doesn't *matter* if the Inspector was real or if the girl died. "The *fact* is, we all *did* what we did," Sheila says. They have accepted their guilt and have been fundamentally changed.
- **The Final Twist:** As the older Birlings are celebrating, the **telephone rings**. Mr. Birling answers it. His face goes white. He tells the family: "That was the police. A girl has just died on her way to the Infirmary... after swallowing some disinfectant. And an inspector

is on his way... to ask some questions." The play ends on this line as they all stare, "aghast."

THEMES

- **SOCIAL AND COLLECTIVE RESPONSIBILITY:** This is the play's main message, encapsulated in the Inspector's final speech ("We are members of one body"). Priestley argues against the capitalist idea of "every man for himself" and demands that we care for the "Eva Smiths" of the world.
- **CLASS HYPOCRISY AND SOCIAL INEQUALITY:** The play exposes the rotten core beneath the "respectable" surface of the Edwardian upper class. The Birlings exploit the poor (Mr. Birling), abuse them (Eric, Gerald), and show them no charity (Mrs. Birling), all while believing they are good, moral people.
- **THE OLDER VS. THE YOUNGER GENERATION:** The Birlings' "bubble" divides the family. The older generation (Arthur and Sybil) are "un-teachable." They are fixed in their selfish ways and learn nothing. The younger generation (Eric and Sheila) are the hope for the future. They are capable of remorse, change, and accepting responsibility.
- **JUDGEMENT AND TIME:** The play functions as a moral judgement. The Inspector gives the family a *warning*. They fail the warning. The "real" inspector and "real" death at the end suggest a "time loop"—they are now trapped and must face the *real-world* consequences of their actions.

STYLE AND CHARACTERIZATION

STYLE

- **THE "WELL-MADE PLAY":** The play follows a tight, three-act structure where tension rises, secrets are revealed (one by one), and there is a stunning climax and twist ending.
- **DRAMATIC IRONY:** The play is filled with it. The audience knows Mr. Birling is wrong about the *Titanic* and the wars, which makes his entire philosophy look foolish and discredited from the start.

- **SINGLE SETTING:** The use of one room (the dining room) makes the play claustrophobic. The Birlings cannot escape the Inspector or their own guilt.

CHARACTERIZATION

- **INSPECTOR GOOLE:**
 - **Role:** The "catalyst" or driving force of the play.
 - **Traits:** Mysterious, omniscient (all-knowing), imposing, and single-minded.
 - **Symbolism:** He is not a "real" person. His name ("Goole" = "Ghoul") suggests he is a supernatural being, a ghost, or an angel—the voice of Priestley's socialist conscience sent to judge the family.
- **MR. ARTHUR BIRLING:** The "villain." He is arrogant, pompous, selfish, and represents the evils of capitalism.
- **MRS. SYBIL BIRLING:** Colder and more cruel than her husband. She is a snob, obsessed with "class" and reputation, and feels no remorse.
- **SHEILA BIRLING:** The "most changed." She begins as a naive, giggling girl and becomes a strong, perceptive, and deeply moral woman. She is the play's "new" conscience.
- **ERIC BIRLING:** Weak, nervous, and a victim of his parents' bad example. However, like Sheila, he is capable of feeling guilt and wanting to change.
- **GERALD CROFT:** The "in-between." He is an aristocrat, more polished than the Birlings, but ultimately sides with the older generation, prioritizing business and reputation over morality.

SOCIAL COMMENTARY AND MORAL IMPLICATIONS

The play is a parable. Eva Smith represents the entire working class. The Birlings represent the entire ruling class. Priestley's moral is a direct socialist command: If we do not learn to take care of "each other" and share our "wealth" (like a Welfare State), we will be doomed to repeat the cycle of "fire and blood and anguish" (wars and revolutions).

EVALUATION

1. What is Eric's involvement with Eva Smith?
2. Summarize the Inspector's final speech in your own words.
3. How do the reactions of the "older" Birlings and "younger" Birlings differ after the Inspector leaves?
4. What is the significance of the final telephone call?

ASSIGNMENT

"The Inspector isn't a real person." Discuss this statement. What is the Inspector's true role or function in *An Inspector Calls*? (300 words).



WEEK 10: NON-AFRICAN DRAMA: ROBERT BOLT'S *A MAN FOR ALL SEASONS*

BACKGROUND OF THE PLAYWRIGHT

Robert Bolt (1924–1995) was an English playwright and acclaimed screenwriter (famous for *Lawrence of Arabia* and *Doctor Zhivago*). Like J. B. Priestley, Bolt was a **socialist** and a man of strong political conviction. He was even arrested for protesting nuclear weapons. However, where Priestley focused on *collective* responsibility, Bolt was fascinated by **individual conscience** and the conflict between a person's private self and the demands of the state.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT (BACKGROUND OF THE PLAY)

The play is not fiction; it is based on a real, and very famous, historical conflict from 16th-century England.

- **THE KING'S "GREAT MATTER":** King Henry VIII of England was married to Catherine of Aragon. But she had not given him a male heir, only a daughter (Mary). Henry wanted to divorce Catherine and marry Anne Boleyn.
- **THE RELIGIOUS CONFLICT:** In the 1530s, England was a Catholic country, and the Pope (in Rome) was the head of the Church. The Pope, under pressure from Spain (Catherine's home country), **refused** to grant the divorce.
- **THE BREAK WITH ROME:** In response, Henry VIII made a radical decision. He broke away from the Catholic Church, declared **himself** the new "Supreme Head of the Church of England," and granted his own divorce.
- **THE OATH OF SUPREMACY:** To force his subjects to accept this, Henry demanded they all swear an "oath" (the Act of Supremacy) recognizing his new title. To refuse the oath was **treason**, punishable by death.

THE CENTRAL CONFLICT

This is where the play's hero, **Sir Thomas More**, enters.

- **Who was Thomas More?** More was one of the most respected men in England. He was a brilliant lawyer, a devout Catholic, and the **Lord Chancellor** (the most powerful political position after the King). He was also a close, personal friend of Henry VIII.
- **More's Dilemma:** More is trapped.
 1. As a loyal **Englishman**, he wants to obey his King.
 2. As a devout **Catholic**, he cannot *morally* accept that the King is the head of the Church. His conscience forbids it.
 3. As a brilliant **lawyer**, he knows that if he just **remains silent**, the law cannot *technically* convict him of treason (since treason is an *act* or a *word*, not a *thought*).
- The play is the story of More's attempt to use **silence** as a shield to save his life, while *not* betraying his conscience. His enemies (like Thomas Cromwell) must therefore twist the law and use lies to trap him.

THEMES OF INTEGRITY, CONSCIENCE, AND POWER

- **INTEGRITY AND CONSCIENCE (THE SELF):** This is the central theme. The play's title, *A Man for All Seasons*, refers to More. He is a man whose *self*, whose "conscience," is so solid and unchanging that he is the same man in all "seasons"—in times of good fortune and in times of crisis. He refuses to "sell" his soul.
 - **The Foil:** The character of **Richard Rich** is More's opposite. Rich is a "man for no season." He has no integrity and is "bought" with political power. In the end, Rich **commits perjury** (lies under oath) to condemn More, and in return, he is made Attorney-General of Wales.
 - More's famous line to Rich: "It profits a man nothing to give his soul for the whole world... But for Wales, Richard?"
- **POWER (THE STATE VS. THE INDIVIDUAL):** The play is a timeless conflict between the absolute power of the state (personified by King Henry VIII and the ruthless Thomas Cromwell) and the private conscience of a single individual. It asks, "Does a person have the right to defy the state if the state is immoral?"
- **THE LAW, MORALITY, AND SILENCE:** More is not a simple rebel. He *loves* the law. He tries to use it as a "shield." He believes that as long as he stays silent, he is

legally safe. The tragedy is that his enemies are willing to *break* the law (by using a perjured witness) to destroy him. His "silence" is ultimately not enough to save him from a corrupt system.

- **THE "COMMON MAN":** Bolt uses a unique character called "The Common Man" who plays many roles (More's steward, a boatman, the jailer, a juror). He represents the "average person" who is amoral, pragmatic, and just "goes along" with the powerful to survive. He is the opposite of More's heroic integrity.

EVALUATION

1. Who was Sir Thomas More, and what was his historical "dilemma"?
2. What is the "Act of Supremacy," and why did More refuse to swear it?
3. Explain the meaning of the title, *A Man for All Seasons*.
4. Contrast the characters of Thomas More and Richard Rich. What does each man value?

ASSIGNMENT

J.B. Priestley's *An Inspector Calls* is about **collective** responsibility ("We are members of one body"). Robert Bolt's *A Man for All Seasons* is about **individual** responsibility (a man's private conscience).

In 300 words, compare these two ideas. Which do you think is a more important message, and why?

WEEK 11: REVISION

This week is dedicated to a comprehensive review of all topics and plays covered during the second term.

SUMMARY OF KEY CONCEPTS

- **WEEK 1 (Introduction to African Drama):**
 - Defined by its **function** (didactic, ritualistic, communal).
 - A "total theatre" that **integrates** music, dance, song, and mime.
 - Rooted in **oral tradition** (storytellers, proverbs, folktales).
 - Features **audience participation** and symbolic masks/costumes.
- **WEEKS 2 & 3 (*Once Upon an Elephant*):**
 - **Genre:** A modern **ecocritical fable/allegory**.
 - **Plot:** The animals of "Animalu" suffer a drought caused by the greed of **King Elephant**, who hoards the water. The **Tortoise (Alawin)** uses his "wit" (intelligence) to trick the King into releasing the water.
 - **Themes:** Abuse of power, environmental justice (ecocriticism), wit vs. might, and collective resistance.
 - **Characters:** King Elephant (tyrant), Tortoise (trickster-hero), Hyena (sycophant).
- **WEEKS 4 & 6 (*The Marriage of Anansewa*):**
 - **Genre:** "Anansegoro," a style blending traditional Ananse storytelling (with a Storyteller and *Mboguo* - song/dance) with modern theatre.
 - **Plot:** **Ananse** (the trickster) uses a **typewriter** to "marry" his daughter **Anansewa** to four chiefs at once to collect gifts. When they all come to claim her, he fakes her **death** to collect funeral money. The one "worthy" suitor (**Chief-Who-Is-Chief**) shows true grief and "wins" the "resurrected" Anansewa.
 - **Themes:** Greed, Tradition vs. Modernity (abuse of custom for profit), Appearance vs. Reality.
- **WEEKS 8 & 9 (*An Inspector Calls*):**
 - **Context:** Set in **1912** (arrogant capitalism), written in **1945** (socialist message).

- **Plot:** The mysterious **Inspector Goole** visits the wealthy **Birling family** and proves that each one of them (Mr., Mrs., Sheila, Eric, and Gerald) had a role in the "chain of events" that led to the suicide of a working-class girl, **Eva Smith**.
- **Twist:** The Inspector is a "hoax," but the family *is* guilty. The "Old" (parents) are relieved and learn nothing. The "Young" (Eric, Sheila) are changed. The play ends with a phone call: a real girl has died, and a real inspector is coming.
- **Themes:** **Collective social responsibility** ("We are members of one body"), class hypocrisy, and Old vs. Young.
- **WEEK 10 (*A Man for All Seasons*):**
 - **Context:** Based on the 16th-century conflict between **King Henry VIII** and **Sir Thomas More**.
 - **Plot:** The King demands More swear the **Act of Supremacy**. More, a devout Catholic, refuses on **conscience** but tries to use **silence** as a legal defense. He is ultimately trapped by the perjury (lies) of a corrupt, ambitious man, **Richard Rich**.
 - **Themes:** **Individual conscience** and integrity, state vs. individual, law vs. morality. More is the "Man for All Seasons" because his "self" is not for sale.

FINAL TERM ASSIGNMENT (Exam Preparation)

Answer **one** of the following questions in a well-structured essay (300–400 words).

1. Compare and contrast the two African "trickster" figures: Alawin (the Tortoise) in *Once Upon an Elephant* and Ananse in *The Marriage of Anansewa*. How do they use their intelligence, and what are their motivations?
2. Both *An Inspector Calls* and *Once Upon an Elephant* are allegories about corrupt leaders and social responsibility. Compare the character of King Elephant to Mr. Arthur Birling. How are they similar in their attitudes, and how do their "downfalls" differ?
3. "Silence is a weapon." Discuss this statement in relation to two plays: *An Inspector Calls* (where the Birlings are forced to *break* their silence) and *A Man for All Seasons* (where Thomas More tries to *use* silence as a shield).

SS1 LITERATURE-IN-ENGLISH LESSON NOTES

THIRD TERM

WEEK 1: INTRODUCTION TO PROSE

FEATURES OF PROSE

Prose is one of the three main genres of literature (along with poetry and drama). It is defined as written or spoken language in its **ordinary, non-metrical form**. Unlike poetry, it does not have a formal rhythmic structure or rhyme scheme.

- **Form:** It is written in **sentences**, which are grouped into **paragraphs**. In longer works (like novels), paragraphs are grouped into **chapters**.
- **Language:** The language is typically "ordinary" or "natural," meaning it follows the natural flow of speech and grammatical rules. This is in contrast to the heightened, compressed, and rhythmic language of poetry.
- **Purpose:** The primary purpose of prose is to **narrate** (tell a story), **describe**, **inform**, or **argue**.
- **Varieties:** Prose can be fictional (imaginative, like novels and short stories) or non-fictional (based on fact, like biographies, essays, and textbooks).

ELEMENTS OF PROSE

To analyze a work of prose fiction, we must break it down into its core components or elements.

PLOT

Plot is the **sequence of related events** that make up the story. It is the "what happens" in the narrative and how the events are organized to create an effect.

- **Exposition:** The beginning of the story, where the setting, main characters, and basic conflict are introduced.

- **Rising Action:** The series of conflicts and complications that build suspense and lead to the climax.
- **Climax:** The highest point of tension, the "turning point" of the story, where the conflict comes to a head.
- **Falling Action:** The events that occur immediately after the climax, where the tension begins to ease.
- **Resolution (or Dénouement):** The end of the story, where the main conflict is resolved and a new "normal" is established.

SETTING

Setting is the **time (when)** and **place (where)** the story occurs. It is the "backdrop" for the action.

- **Physical Setting:** The geographical location (e.g., a city, a village, a forest, a specific room).
- **Temporal Setting:** The time period (e.g., the 1930s, the 21st century, during a specific war, over the course of one day).
- **Social/Cultural Setting:** The customs, values, and social norms of the society in which the story is set. (e.g., a racist town in the 1930s).
- **Function:** Setting is not just a backdrop; it can create **mood**, influence **character** behavior, and sometimes be a source of **conflict** itself.

CHARACTERIZATION

Characterization is the **method a writer uses to create and develop the people** (or "actors") in the story.

- **Protagonist:** The main character, who the story revolves around.
- **Antagonist:** The character or force that opposes the protagonist.
- **Direct Characterization:** The author **tells** the reader directly what a character is like (e.g., "Sade was a kind and generous woman.").
- **Indirect Characterization:** The author **shows** the reader what a character is like through their actions, speech, thoughts, and how other characters react to them.

- **Types of Characters:**

- **Round/Dynamic:** A complex, multi-faceted character who *changes* and *grows* throughout the story.
- **Flat/Static:** A simple, one-dimensional character who *does not* change.

THEME

Theme is the **central idea, message, or underlying meaning** of the story. It is a universal truth or observation about life or human nature that the author explores.

- **Note:** A theme is *not* a single word (e.g., "Love"). It is a *statement* or *idea* about that word (e.g., "Love requires great sacrifice" or "Love can be a destructive force").
- A story can have one major theme and several minor themes.

POINT OF VIEW (POV)

Point of View is the **perspective or "lens" from which the story is told.**

- **First-Person POV:** The narrator is a character *in* the story and uses the pronoun "**I**" (e.g., "I walked down the street."). The reader only knows what this one character knows, thinks, and sees.
- **Third-Person Limited POV:** The narrator is *outside* the story and uses pronouns "**he,**" "**she,**" or "**they.**" The narrator knows the thoughts and feelings of *only one* character.
- **Third-Person Omniscient (All-Knowing) POV:** The narrator is *outside* the story and is "all-knowing." This "god-like" narrator can tell the reader what *all* the characters are thinking and feeling, and can be in multiple places at once.

EVALUATION

1. What is the main difference between prose and poetry?
2. Define "Setting" and list its three components.
3. Explain the difference between *direct* and *indirect* characterization.

4. Differentiate between a *First-Person* and a *Third-Person Omniscient* point of view.

ASSIGNMENT

Read any short story (a folktale or a story from a book). In 250 words, identify and describe its: a) Protagonist and Antagonist b) Setting c) Main Theme



WEEK 2: AFRICAN PROSE: PEDE HOLLIST'S *SO THE PATH DOES NOT DIE* I

BACKGROUND OF THE AUTHOR

Pede Hollist is a Sierra Leonean-American author and academic. He was born in Sierra Leone and later moved to the United States, where he became a professor of English.

This "diaspora" background is the key to understanding his novel. He is deeply interested in the lives of **African immigrants in the West** and the complex relationship they have with the "home" they left behind. His work explores themes of **identity, belonging, and the "returnee" experience**. *So the Path Does Not Die* is his first novel and reflects these core interests.

SETTING

The novel has two primary, contrasting settings, which are central to the entire conflict:

1. **THE UNITED STATES (Diaspora):** Specifically, **Tampa, Florida**. This setting represents **modernity, individualism, Western education, and a "new life."** It is where the protagonist, Fina, has built her adult identity. It is a world of academic life, different social rules, and romantic relationships outside her culture.
2. **SIERRA LEONE (Home):** Specifically, **Freetown** and the village of **Rotifunk**. This setting represents **tradition, community, family obligation, and "roots."** It is the "path" of the title. It is a world of ancestral expectations, communal responsibilities, and a culture that is struggling with its own post-colonial problems.

The tension between these two "worlds" is what drives the novel.

PLOT SUMMARY (CHAPTERS 1–4)

- **Exposition (Chapter 1):** We are introduced to the protagonist, **Adefinah "Fina" M'bayo**, in her apartment in Tampa, Florida. She is a Sierra Leonean immigrant, a university graduate, and is living with her African-American boyfriend, **Chris**. Her life seems stable and "American."

- **The Inciting Incident:** Fina receives a series of phone calls and emails from her family back in Sierra Leone. The news is urgent: her **father is critically ill**. This news acts as a "summons," pulling her back towards the "home" she has been away from for years.
- **Internal Conflict (Chapters 2-3):** Fina is immediately thrown into a state of internal conflict. She feels a deep sense of **guilt** for being away for so long. She is torn between her *current life* (her job, her relationship with Chris, who doesn't understand her obligations) and her *past life* (her duty as a daughter, the expectations of her family).
- **The Decision:** The news of her father's illness, and the pressure from her family, forces her to make a decision. She must return to Sierra Leone.
- **Preparation and Departure (Chapter 4):** Fina begins the difficult process of preparing for her trip. This involves navigating her relationship with Chris, who feels threatened by her "other life," and the complex logistics of traveling. The early chapters establish the central question: Is Fina an American, or is she a Sierra Leonean? Can she be both? Her journey "home" is a journey to find her own identity—to ensure the "path" to her roots does not die.

EVALUATION

1. Who is Pede Hollist, and how does his personal background influence the novel?
2. Describe the two main settings of the novel and what each one represents.
3. Who is Fina, and what is her life like at the very beginning of the novel?
4. What "inciting incident" sets the entire plot in motion?

ASSIGNMENT

In 200 words, describe the *internal conflict* that Fina faces in the first few chapters. What two "worlds" is she torn between?

WEEK 3: AFRICAN PROSE: *SO THE PATH DOES NOT DIE II*

THEMES

(This section covers the entire novel)

- **THE SEARCH FOR IDENTITY AND "HOME":** This is the central theme. Fina suffers from a "hybrid identity" or "double consciousness." In America, she is "African." In Sierra Leone, she is now the "American" returnee. The novel asks: What is "home"? Is it the place you are born, or the place you build a life? Fina must forge a new identity that honors both her roots (the "path") and her "routes" (her life's journey).
- **TRADITION VS. MODERNITY:** Fina, a modern, Western-educated, and independent woman, is thrust back into a society with very traditional expectations. Her family and community expect her to behave in a certain way—to be a "good daughter," to marry a Sierra Leonean man, and to fulfill family obligations. Her journey is a constant negotiation between these two value systems.
- **THE DIASPORA EXPERIENCE (THE "RETURNEE"):** The novel is a powerful exploration of the "returnee" experience. Fina returns "home" only to find that she is now an outsider. She sees her country with "new eyes," noticing both its beauty and its problems (poverty, "brain drain"). The title itself, *So the Path Does Not Die*, is a plea for the diaspora to remain connected to their origins.
- **LOVE AND CULTURAL EXPECTATIONS:** Fina's romantic relationships symbolize her cultural conflict. Her relationship with **Chris** (African-American) represents her American life, but he cannot understand the pull of her "path." Her emerging relationship with **Bola** (a Sierra Leonean doctor) represents a possible *reintegration* into her home culture, but on her own, modern terms.

STYLE

- **LANGUAGE AND VOICE:** Hollist's style is realistic and introspective. The narrative is deeply embedded in Fina's thoughts and feelings (a *Third-Person Limited* point of view).

- **CODE-SWITCHING AND KRIO:** To create an authentic Sierra Leonean atmosphere, Hollist skillfully weaves **Krio** (the lingua franca of Sierra Leone) and local proverbs into the dialogue. This "code-switching" reflects Fina's own hybrid world.
- **SYMBOLISM:**
 - **The Path:** The central symbol. It represents Fina's "roots," her heritage, her connection to her family, and her identity. Her journey is about "clearing" this path so it does not become overgrown and "die."
 - **The Atlantic Ocean:** A symbol of both connection and separation—the "Middle Passage" that separates Africa from the diaspora.

CHARACTERIZATION

- **ADEFINAH "FINA" M'BAYO:** The **protagonist**. She is a **round and dynamic** character. She begins the novel in a state of cultural confusion and guilt. Her journey to Sierra Leone forces her to confront her past, her family, and herself. She grows from being a person *torn between* two worlds to a person who *bridges* them.
- **CHRIS:** Fina's African-American boyfriend. He is not a villain, but he is an **antagonist** to her *cultural* journey. He represents the "American" perspective, which is different from the "African immigrant" perspective. He highlights the "disconnect" within the African diaspora.
- **FINA'S FAMILY (FATHER, AUNT, ETC.):** They function as the "pull of tradition" and the voice of "home." They are the guardians of the "path" and represent the community and family obligations that Fina is struggling with.
- **BOLA:** The Sierra Leonean doctor. He represents a "new" Sierra Leone—educated, dedicated to his country, and modern, yet still rooted in the culture. He offers Fina a *possible* future that combines both her modern self and her Sierra Leonean roots.

SOCIO-CULTURAL ISSUES IN THE TEXT

- **"Brain Drain":** The novel implicitly critiques the "brain drain"—the migration of Africa's most educated and talented individuals (like Fina and Bola) to the West.

- **Post-Colonial Africa:** The novel shows a modern Sierra Leone, a nation grappling with its own identity, poverty, and the challenges of development.
- **Family Obligation:** It highlights the immense pressure of family and communal obligations in many African societies, contrasting it with Western individualism.

EVALUATION

1. Explain the central theme of "Tradition vs. Modernity" using Fina as an example.
2. What is the meaning of the title, *So the Path Does Not Die*? What is the "path"?
3. Compare and contrast Fina's two romantic interests, Chris and Bola. What does each man represent?
4. Define "code-switching" and explain why Pede Hollist uses it in the novel.

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 250-word essay on the topic: "Is Fina a round or flat character?" Explain your answer using evidence from the novel.

WEEK 4: NON-AFRICAN PROSE: HARPER LEE'S *TO KILL A MOCKINGBIRD* I

BACKGROUND OF THE AUTHOR

Harper Lee (1926–2016) was an American novelist. She was born and raised in **Monroeville, Alabama**, a small Southern town that serves as the direct inspiration for the novel's setting.

- **Semi-Autobiographical:** The novel is deeply personal. Lee's father, Amasa Coleman Lee, was a lawyer and a member of the Alabama state legislature, just like the character **Atticus Finch**.
- **Historical Context:** Lee grew up in the **Jim Crow South**, a time and place of strict, legal **racial segregation** and intense prejudice. The novel was written in the 1950s and published in 1960, right at the beginning of the **Civil Rights Movement**.
- **The Scottsboro Boys:** A famous (and infamous) real-life trial in the 1930s, where nine young, poor Black men were falsely accused of raping two white women in Alabama. Despite overwhelming evidence of their innocence, they were convicted by all-white juries. This event is a major parallel to the fictional trial of Tom Robinson in the novel.

PLOT SUMMARY (CHAPTERS 1–5)

- **Introduction (Chapter 1):** The story is narrated by an adult **Jean Louise "Scout" Finch**, who is looking back on her childhood. She introduces her family: her father, **Atticus Finch** (a respected lawyer), her older brother, **Jem**, and their cook, **Calpurnia**. She sets the scene in their "tired old town" of **Maycomb, Alabama**.
- **Dill (Chapter 1):** The "childhood" plot begins when a new boy named **Charles Baker "Dill" Harris** comes to spend the summer. Dill becomes obsessed with a "malevolent phantom" who lives in a "haunted" house on their street: **Arthur "Boo" Radley**.
- **The Radley Obsession (Chapters 1-3):** The first few chapters are dominated by the children's fascination with Boo Radley. They dare each other to touch the house, create "plays" about his life, and try to get him to come out. Boo represents the **mystery, superstition, and prejudice** of Maycomb.
- **School (Chapters 2-3):** Scout starts school, and it is a disaster. Her teacher, Miss Caroline, is new to Maycomb and does not understand its social rules. Scout gets in

trouble for already knowing how to read (Atticus taught her) and for trying to explain the **social hierarchy** of Maycomb (e.g., why Walter Cunningham won't accept a quarter).

- **The Cunninghams and Ewells (Chapter 3):** We are introduced to two poor white families who represent different "types" of poverty. The **Cunninghams** are poor but proud and honest. The **Ewells** (like Burris Ewell) are "white trash"—dirty, disrespectful, and live "like animals."
- **Gifts in the Tree (Chapter 4):** As the children's obsession with Boo continues, they begin to find mysterious gifts (gum, Indian-head pennies) left in the knothole of an oak tree on the Radley property. This is the first sign that Boo is not a "phantom," but a real, and perhaps kind, person.

SETTING AND TONE

SETTING

- **MAYCOMB, ALABAMA (1933–1935):** This is the single most important element.
- **Time: The Great Depression.** This explains the widespread poverty of families like the Cunninghams and the general "slow" pace of the town.
- **Place:** A small, fictional Southern town. It is "a tired old town."
- **Social Atmosphere:** The town is rigid, gossipy, and governed by **Jim Crow laws** (racial segregation). It is a deeply **racist and prejudiced** society. The "disease" of Maycomb is its prejudice, which Atticus must fight.

TONE

- The tone of the novel is established by its **dual-narrator** perspective. It is narrated by an **adult Scout** looking back at her **childhood self**.
- This creates a tone that is:
 1. **Nostalgic and Anecdotal:** The adult narrator remembers her childhood with humor and fondness.
 2. **Innocent and Observant:** The "child" narrator (Scout) observes the adult world with a logical, simple, and unbiased eye. This "innocent" perspective is what makes the town's racism seem so absurd and illogical.

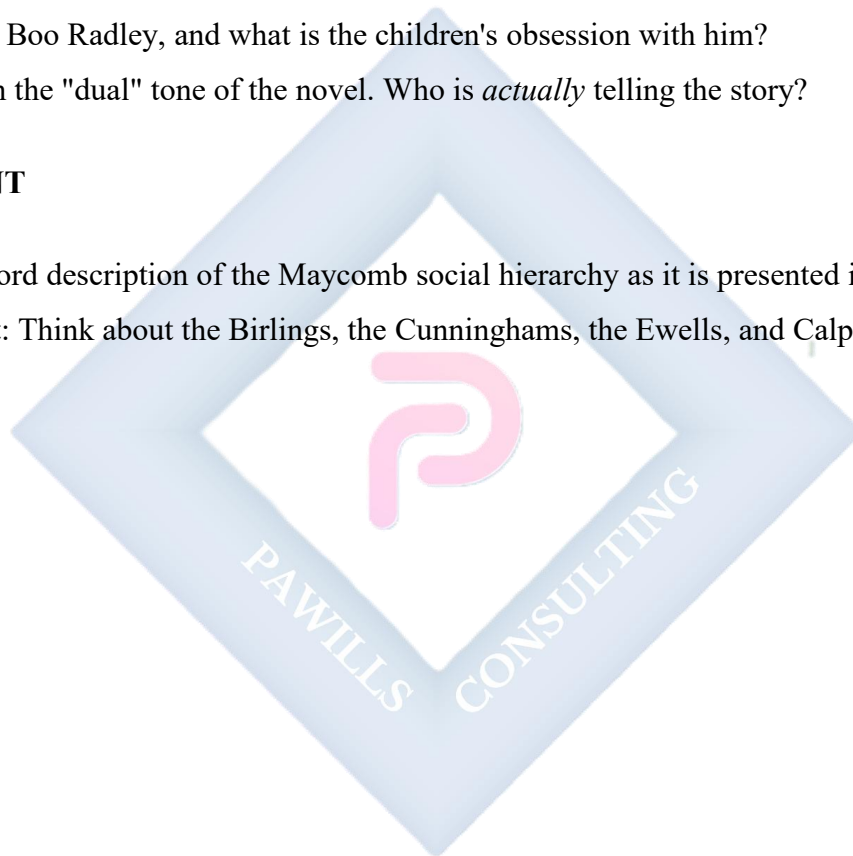
- The tone is light and humorous in the early chapters, but it will grow **darker and more somber** as the trial begins.

EVALUATION

1. How is Harper Lee's own life reflected in the novel *To Kill a Mockingbird*?
2. Describe the setting of Maycomb, Alabama. What is the "social atmosphere" of the town?
3. Who is Boo Radley, and what is the children's obsession with him?
4. Explain the "dual" tone of the novel. Who is *actually* telling the story?

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 250-word description of the Maycomb social hierarchy as it is presented in the first few chapters. (Hint: Think about the Birlings, the Cunninghams, the Ewells, and Calpurnia).



WEEK 6: NON-AFRICAN PROSE: *TO KILL A MOCKINGBIRD* II

(This section covers the entire novel)

THEMES

- **RACISM AND SOCIAL INJUSTICE:** This is the novel's central theme. The town of Maycomb is deeply racist. This is shown through the **Tom Robinson trial**, where an innocent Black man is convicted of rape simply because the jury will not take his word over a white woman's. The novel exposes the "disease" of prejudice that infects the entire town.
- **INNOCENCE AND THE LOSS OF INNOCENCE:** The title, *To Kill a Mockingbird*, is the central metaphor. Atticus tells the children it is "a sin to kill a mockingbird" because they are innocent creatures who only "sing their hearts out for us."
 - The "Mockingbirds" in the novel are **Tom Robinson** and **Boo Radley**—two innocent, harmless men who are destroyed by the "evil" of society (racism and prejudice).
 - The trial forces **Jem and Scout** to lose their childhood innocence as they discover the ugliness and hypocrisy of the adult world.
- **COURAGE (MORAL VS. PHYSICAL):** The novel redefines courage. It's not "a man with a gun in his hand" (though Atticus *is* a good shot). True courage is **moral courage**:
 - **Atticus** shows courage by taking Tom's case, knowing he will lose and that it will put his family in danger.
 - **Mrs. Dubose**, an old, racist woman, shows courage by fighting her morphine addiction, determined to "die free."
- **PREJUDICE (BEYOND RACE):** The novel also explores other forms of prejudice:
 - **Class Prejudice:** The town looks down on the poor Cunninghams and the "white trash" Ewells.
 - **Social Prejudice:** The townspeople gossip about and "imprison" Boo Radley in his home because he is "different."
 - **Gender Prejudice:** Scout is constantly told to "stop being a girl" and to act "like a lady."

CHARACTER ANALYSIS

- **SCOUT (JEAN LOUISE FINCH):** The **narrator and protagonist**. She is a *tomboy*—intelligent, outspoken, and quick-tempered. The novel is a *bildungsroman* (a coming-of-age story) about her journey from innocence to experience. Her child's perspective exposes the hypocrisy of Maycomb.
- **ATTICUS FINCH:** The novel's **moral center**. He is a "hero." A respected lawyer, a widower, and a patient father. He represents **integrity, justice, quiet courage, and empathy**. He is the moral compass of Maycomb and teaches his children to "climb into someone's skin and walk around in it."
- **JEM FINCH:** Scout's older brother. He is idealistic and protective. The injustice of the Tom Robinson trial hits him the hardest, shattering his faith in the world and forcing him into adolescence.
- **BOO RADLEY (ARTHUR):** The "phantom" neighbor. He is a "mockingbird," a recluse who was psychologically damaged by his cruel father. He is a victim of social prejudice. He is a **symbol of hidden kindness**—watching over the children, leaving them gifts, and ultimately **saving their lives** from Bob Ewell.
- **TOM ROBINSON:** The innocent Black man accused of rape. He is the novel's *other* "mockingbird." He is a symbol of the racial injustice of the South.
- **BOB EWELL:** The **antagonist**. A poor, hateful, racist man. He represents the "evil" side of Maycomb—the "white trash" who, despite being at the bottom of the white social ladder, clings to his racial superiority.

STYLE

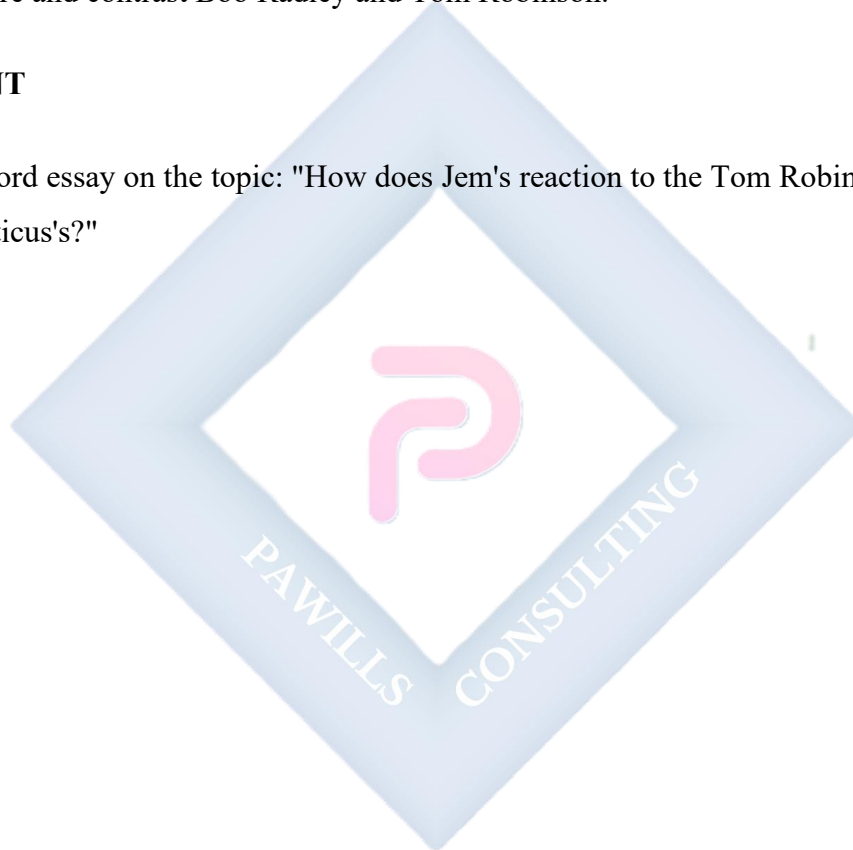
- **FIRST-PERSON NARRATIVE (PAST TENSE):** The story is told by an adult Scout, which allows Harper Lee to blend the **innocent observations of a child** with the **mature reflection of an adult**. This dual perspective is the novel's greatest strength.
- **SOUTHERN GOTHIC:** The novel uses elements of "Southern Gothic"—a style that focuses on the dark, "haunted" side of the South. Boo Radley, the "mad" dog, the dark secrets of the town, and the decaying social structure are all Gothic elements.

EVALUATION

1. Explain the meaning of the title, *To Kill a Mockingbird*. Who are the two main "mockingbirds" in the novel, and why?
2. What is "moral courage," and how does Atticus Finch demonstrate it?
3. Why is the novel's style (a child narrator) so effective in its critique of racism?
4. Compare and contrast Boo Radley and Tom Robinson.

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 300-word essay on the topic: "How does Jem's reaction to the Tom Robinson trial verdict differ from Atticus's?"



WEEK 8: AFRICAN POETRY I

GABRIEL OKARA – "ONCE UPON A TIME"

- **THE POEM (ANALYSIS):** This is a poem of **nostalgia and lament**. The speaker, a father, is talking to his "son." He describes how he *used* to be—genuine, open, and able to "laugh with [his] heart." But now, living in a modern, Westernized, "hypocritical" world, he has learned to be false. He "laughs with [his] teeth," wears "faces" (like masks or "dresses"), and has forgotten how to be real. He asks his son to "unlearn" these false behaviors and "relearn" how to be genuine.
- **THEMES:**
 - **Loss of Innocence/Cultural Nostalgia:** The "once upon a time" was a time of genuine African cultural innocence.
 - **Hypocrisy:** The phoniness and fakeness of modern society.
 - **Cultural Conflict (Africa vs. West):** The poem laments the loss of traditional values to cold, Western "modernity."
- **TONE:** Nostalgic, melancholic, regretful, cynical.
- **POETIC DEVICES:**
 - **Repetition:** "Once upon a time," "laugh," "good-bye." This emphasizes the loss.
 - **Simile:** "laugh... like a snake's bare fangs" (showing that the new laugh is dangerous and false).
 - **Metaphor:** "I have learned to wear many faces / Like dresses" (Metaphor of emotions/personalities as clothing, easily changed and artificial).

NIYI OSUNDARE – "NOT MY BUSINESS"

- **THE POEM (ANALYSIS):** This is a powerful **political** poem about **apathy and its consequences**. The speaker observes as an oppressive force ("They") comes for his neighbors, one by one. First, "They" take Akanni (for being "too bold"). Then, Danladi (for "stretching" his mat "too wide"). Then, Chinwe (for her "ideas"). Each time, the speaker does nothing and comforts himself by saying, **"What concerns me... / Not my business."** In the final stanza, "They" come for *him*, and there is "no one left" to speak up.

- **THEMES:**
 - **Political Oppression:** The poem critiques brutal dictatorships (like in 1990s Nigeria, when it was written).
 - **Social Apathy/Complicity:** The central theme. It attacks the "every man for himself" attitude.
 - **The Price of Silence:** It shows that silence in the face of injustice is not "safe"—it is a delayed death sentence.
- **TONE: Detached, casual, and sarcastic (in the stanzas) ... then changing to desperate, panicked, and terrified (in the final stanza).**
- **POETIC DEVICES:**
 - **Repetition (Refrain):** The line "Not my business" is repeated as a refrain, highlighting the speaker's deliberate and foolish apathy.
 - **Allusion/Symbolism:** The names (Akanni - Yoruba, Danladi - Hausa, Chinwe - Igbo) are used to show that the oppression is *national*, cutting across all ethnic groups.
 - **Simple Diction:** The language is very simple and narrative, like a news report, making the events feel chillingly normal.

EVALUATION

1. In "Once Upon a Time," what is the *difference* between "laughing with the heart" and "laughing with the teeth"?
2. What does the speaker in "Once Upon a Time" want his son to teach him?
3. What is the central "crime" of Akanni, Danladi, and Chinwe in "Not My Business"?
4. Explain the poem's final stanza. What is the moral lesson of "Not My Business"?

ASSIGNMENT

Compare the "loss" experienced by the speaker in "Once Upon a Time" to the "loss" experienced by the speaker in "Not My Business." (250 words).



WEEK 9: AFRICAN POETRY II

WOLE SOYINKA – "NIGHT"

- **THE POEM (ANALYSIS):** This is a complex, dense, and atmospheric poem. Soyinka (a Nigerian Nobel Laureate) is not just describing "night time"; he is describing **"Night" as a powerful, living presence**. The poem is a sensory journey into the darkness, which is portrayed as both **threatening** (a source of "dread") and **creative** (a womb, a source of mystery). The speaker is a "suppliant" (a worshipper) at the "altar" of the night, waiting for a revelation. The poem is about the thin line between the physical world and the spiritual world (of gods, ancestors, or death) that the night represents.
- **THEMES:**
 - **Spirituality and Mystery:** The night as a time of spiritual connection and deep, unfathomable mystery.
 - **Creation and Destruction:** The night is a "womb" (creative) but also a source of "dread" (destructive).
 - **The Subconscious:** The poem can be read as a journey into the "night" of the human mind or soul.
- **TONE: Somber, meditative, mystical, ominous, and awestruck.**
- **IMAGERY AND SYMBOLISM:**
 - **Night:** The central symbol, personified as a powerful entity or god.
 - **"Gourds of darkness":** An image of night as a vessel, full of potential or poison.
 - **"Metal leaves":** An industrial image that contrasts with the natural night, perhaps suggesting the harshness of modern life.
- **STRUCTURE: Free Verse.** The poem's structure is complex, with long, winding sentences and enjambment (lines running into each other), which mimics the feeling of being lost in deep thought or darkness.

SYL CHENEY-COKER – "THE BREAST OF THE SEA"

- **THE POEM (ANALYSIS):** This is a passionate, lyrical poem from a Sierra Leonean poet. The speaker expresses a deep, almost physical **connection to the African**

continent, which he symbolizes as "**the breast of the sea.**" The sea is not just water; it is a **mother** (a "breast"), a source of life, and an archive of **history and memory**. The speaker's "agony" and "blood" are mixed with the "salt" of the sea. The poem is a "homecoming," a desperate and passionate reconnection with his African identity, which is forever marked by the "agony" of its history (e.g., the slave trade, which crossed that same sea).

- **THEMES:**

- **Pan-Africanism/Connection to Roots:** A deep, spiritual connection to Africa.
- **History and Memory:** The sea as a witness to the history and suffering (the "agony") of the African people.
- **The Poet's Identity:** The speaker defines himself *through* his connection to his land.

- **TONE:** Passionate, agonized, intense, lyrical, and yearning.

- **IMAGERY AND SYMBOLISM:**

- **"The Breast of the Sea":** The central **metaphor**. The sea is a life-giving, maternal force that represents Africa itself.
- **"Agony":** Represents the personal suffering of the poet, but also the *collective* suffering and history of his people.
- **"Blood" and "Salt":** Imagery that connects the human body (blood) to the sea (salt), making the connection physical and unbreakable.

- **STRUCTURE:** Free Verse, with a strong, passionate rhythm.

EVALUATION

1. In "Night," is the "night" presented as a good thing, a bad thing, or something else? Explain.
2. What does the "metal leaves" imagery suggest in Soyinka's poem?
3. What is the central metaphor in "The Breast of the Sea"? What does it represent?
4. Why does the speaker in Cheney-Coker's poem associate the sea with "agony"?

ASSIGNMENT

Write a 250-word essay comparing the *atmosphere* (the feeling/mood) of "Night" to the *atmosphere* of "The Breast of the Sea."



WEEK 10: NON-AFRICAN POETRY

MAYA ANGELOU – "STILL I RISE"

- **THE POEM (ANALYSIS):** This is a powerful, celebrated **anthem of defiance and resilience**. The speaker is addressing her **oppressors** (racists, misogynists, and all of society that tries to "break" her). She confronts them directly, asking if her "sassiness" and "haughtiness" upset them. She defiantly states that no matter how they "write [her] down in history" with "bitter, twisted lies" or "kill" her with "hatefulness," she will **always rise**. She compares her resilience to the certainty of the **sun** and **moon** and her value to "**oil wells**" and "**gold mines**." The poem culminates in her claiming her power as "the dream and the hope of the slave."
- **THEMES:**
 - **Resilience and Defiance:** The core theme. The refusal to be defeated.
 - **Overcoming Oppression:** Specifically, the poem is about overcoming racial (Black) and gender (female) oppression.
 - **Self-Worth and Pride:** A powerful declaration of "Black Joy" and pride.
- **TONE:** Defiant, proud, triumphant, sassy, angry, and ultimately, joyful.
- **POETIC DEVICES:**
 - **Repetition (Refrain):** The line "**Still I'll rise**" / "**Still I rise**" acts as a powerful, unifying anthem.
 - **Simile:** "But still, **like dust**, I'll rise"; "Shoulders falling down **like teardrops**."
 - **Rhetorical Questions:** "Does my sassiness upset you?"; "Did you want to see me broken?" (These directly challenge the oppressor).
 - **Metaphor:** She is "black ocean, leaping and wide," and she possesses "gold mines" and "oil wells" (symbols of immense, natural wealth).

LORD BYRON – "SHE WALKS IN BEAUTY"

- **THE POEM (ANALYSIS):** This is a classic poem from the English **Romantic** movement. The speaker is mesmerized by a woman's beauty. He compares her beauty to a "**cloudless... starry**" night. Her perfection is a "tender light" that is a perfect **harmony**

of "dark and bright." The poem's key argument is that her **physical beauty** ("cheek," "brow," "tresses") is a direct *result* of her **inner beauty**. Her "thoughts" are "serenely sweet," and her "mind" and "heart" are "at peace" and "innocent."

- **THEMES:**

- **Beauty (Inner and Outer):** The main theme is that true beauty is a *harmony* of the physical (outer) and the spiritual (inner).
- **Harmony and Perfection:** The poem is obsessed with the perfect balance of "dark and bright," "light and shadow."
- **Innocence:** Her "innocent" heart is the *source* of her beauty.

- **TONE:** Awestruck, admiring, contemplative, romantic, and peaceful.

- **POETIC DEVICES:**

- **Simile:** The very first line: "**She walks in beauty, like the night...**"
- **Alliteration:** "cloudless climes and starry skies."
- **Personification:** "thoughts serenely sweet **express** / How pure, how dear their dwelling-place." (Her thoughts "express" themselves on her face).
- **Structure:** This is *not* free verse. It has a very strict **ABABAB rhyme scheme** and **iambic tetrameter** (eight syllables per line, da-DUM da-DUM). This musical, regular rhythm mirrors the "harmony" and "perfection" he is describing.

EVALUATION

1. In "Still I Rise," who is the speaker addressing?
2. List three things the speaker in "Still I Rise" compares herself to.
3. In "She Walks in Beauty," what does the speaker compare the woman's beauty to?
4. According to Byron, what is the *source* of the woman's outer beauty?

ASSIGNMENT

Compare the "tone" of "Still I Rise" with the "tone" of "She Walks in Beauty." How does the *purpose* of each poem (one to defy, one to admire) affect its tone? (300 words).

WEEK 11: REVISION

This week is dedicated to a comprehensive review of all prose, drama, and poetry texts covered during the year.

SUMMARY OF KEY CONCEPTS AND TEXTS

- **LITERARY GENRES AND DEVICES:**

- **Prose:** Ordinary language (Plot, Setting, Character, Theme, POV).
- **Poetry:** Rhythmic language (Stanza, Rhyme, Meter, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, etc.).
- **Drama:** Performance-based (Dialogue, Stage Directions, Acts, Scenes, Tragedy, Comedy).

- **PROSE:**

- ***So the Path Does Not Die* (Pede Hollist):**
 - **Themes:** Search for identity/home, tradition vs. modernity, the diaspora/returnee experience.
 - **Conflict:** Fina is torn between her "American" life and her "Sierra Leonean" roots (the "path").
- ***To Kill a Mockingbird* (Harper Lee):**
 - **Themes:** Racial injustice, loss of innocence, moral courage, prejudice.
 - **Symbols:** The "Mockingbird" (Tom Robinson, Boo Radley) represents innocence destroyed by evil.

- **AFRICAN POETRY:**

- **"Once Upon a Time" (Okara):** Laments the loss of cultural innocence and the rise of modern hypocrisy ("laughing with teeth").
- **"Not My Business" (Osundare):** A political poem warning against apathy; failure to speak for others means no one will be left to speak for you.
- **"Night" (Soyinka):** A complex, mystical poem personifying "Night" as a powerful, spiritual force of dread and mystery.
- **"The Breast of the Sea" (Cheney-Coker):** A passionate poem connecting the poet's identity to Africa, symbolized by the sea (a mother, a witness to history).

- **NON-AFRICAN POETRY:**

- **"Still I Rise" (Angelou):** A powerful anthem of defiance, resilience, and pride in the face of racial and gender oppression.
- **"She Walks in Beauty" (Byron):** An admiring poem celebrating a woman whose perfect outer beauty is the *result* of her perfect inner innocence and peace.

- **DRAMA (Review from 2nd Term):**

- ***An Inspector Calls* (Priestley):** A socialist parable about **collective responsibility** ("We are members of one body").
- ***A Man for All Seasons* (Bolt):** A historical play about **individual conscience** and the conflict between one man (Thomas More) and the power of the state.

FINAL REVISION ASSIGNMENT

Choose **one** of the following essay topics and write a 300-400 word response, using evidence from at least two texts studied this year.

1. Compare the theme of **Justice and Injustice** in *To Kill a Mockingbird* and *An Inspector Calls*. How do both texts explore this theme, and what "lessons" do they try to teach?
2. Compare the theme of **Identity** in *So the Path Does Not Die* and "Once Upon a Time." How do both texts deal with the conflict between "modern" life and traditional "roots"?
3. Choose two characters: **Atticus Finch** (*To Kill a Mockingbird*) and **Sir Thomas More** (*A Man for All Seasons*). Compare them as men of "courage" and "conscience." How are their struggles similar?